

Aquifer Open Study Notes

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Aquifer Open Study Notes

Deuteronomy 1:1

These are the words that Moses spoke: Although Deuteronomy is modeled after a covenant or treaty document, it is essentially a series of addresses delivered by Moses to the assembly of Israel. • the Jordan Valley: Hebrew *the Arabah*, a common word usually translated “wilderness” or “desert.” It generally refers to the Great Rift Valley that extends from the Sea of Galilee southward to the Red Sea (the Gulf of Aqaba). In this context, the Arabah is the wasteland of the lower Jordan River, just north of the Dead Sea.

Deuteronomy 1:1–5

Ancient Near Eastern treaty texts usually began with a brief section introducing the partners in the covenant, their relationship to each other, and their immediate ancestry. This introduction provides information primarily about the social and geographic setting.

Deuteronomy 1:2

The distance from Mount Sinai in the southern part of the Sinai Peninsula to Kadesh-barnea (see study note on 1:19) in the north is only 150 miles. Even the massive Hebrew population could easily have covered this distance in eleven days had they proceeded without detour or interruption. Their rebellion against the Lord resulted in a 38-year delay and a circuitous route ([2:14](#); [Num 14:34](#)). • Mount Sinai: Hebrew *Horeb*, the name consistently used in Deuteronomy for the sacred mountain where the covenant was given. Its likely connection to a word meaning “drought” or “devastation” suggests the conditions the people of Israel had to face. • The way of Mount Seir was the route from Mount Sinai to Mount Seir. Seir, another name for Edom, was located east-southeast of the Dead Sea. The ordinary route took travelers through the Arabah north from the Gulf of Aqaba and then west to Kadesh-barnea, sixty miles southwest of the Dead Sea.

Deuteronomy 1:4

The Amorites were a Semitic people, linguistically related to the Canaanites. They originally lived in what is now north-central Syria, but they had migrated into Canaan to settle on both sides of the Jordan River, primarily in the hill country. At the time of Israel’s conquest, many Amorites lived in Transjordan (east of the Jordan), north of the Arnon River, with their capital at Heshbon (see also study note on Num 21:13). The Israelites had already displaced many of them before this time ([Num 22:21–35](#)). • Bashan was also an Amorite area, located north of the Yarmuk River and east of the Sea of Galilee. It was known for its prized livestock (cp. [Ps 22:12](#); [Ezek 39:18](#); [Amos 4:1](#) and study note). Its capital was Ashtaroth. • The kings Sihon and Og are not known outside the Bible (see [Num 21:21–35](#)).

Deuteronomy 1:6–4:40

Secular treaties typically included a section detailing the past relations between the treaty partners. The purpose here was to point out Israel’s successes and failures since the Exodus and to remind the people that God had been true to his word regardless of how they had acted toward him. In order to prepare the Israelites for life in Canaan, Moses reminded them of life in Egypt, of the forty years of wandering in the wilderness, and of their past blunders. He warned them to obey God’s covenant and assured them that God’s grace would follow them as they learned to trust and obey the Lord.

Deuteronomy 1:7

The hill country consisted of interior areas of Canaan that were also inhabited by the Amorites (see [1:4](#); [Num 13:29](#); [Josh 10:6](#)). The Canaanites apparently once lived throughout Palestine, but with the incursion of the Amorites they were restricted to the valleys and lowlands. • the western foothills: Hebrew *the Shephelah*, the term still used in modern Israel for the region between the hills of Judah and the coastal plain, an area that specializes in orchards and vineyards. • the Negev:

This great desert area lies to the south of Canaan. The Hebrew word could also designate “the south.”

Deuteronomy 1:8

occupy it (literally *acquire it as an inheritance*): The land was already Israel’s because God had promised it to the nation’s ancestors centuries earlier ([Gen 15:18–21](#); [26:3](#); [Exod 23:31](#)). Israel was not seizing new territory from its rightful owners but was taking possession of land occupied by squatters.

Deuteronomy 1:9–18

See [Exod 18:13–27](#).

Deuteronomy 1:10

as numerous as the stars: This figure of speech deliberately exaggerates for effect. Abraham’s descendants had not approached the actual number of stars in the universe, though they exceeded the number of stars visible to the naked eye. Moses meant that God had begun fulfilling his promises to Abraham (see [Gen 15:5](#); [22:17](#)) by making Israel numerous, bringing them to the Promised Land, and preparing them to conquer it.

Deuteronomy 1:13

Those who were well-respected had lives and reputations that were above reproach, even on close scrutiny.

Deuteronomy 1:15

thousand . . . hundred . . . fifty . . . ten: This was standard military organization, so some of these officials were probably military officers (see [1 Sam 8:12](#); [22:7](#); [2 Sam 18:1](#)).

Deuteronomy 1:16–17

Be . . . impartial (literally *Do not notice faces*): People appearing before the court should be treated as though they were wearing a mask to

conceal their identity. Judges were not to be influenced by rich and powerful persons in the community but were to judge on the basis of God’s own impartiality ([10:17](#)) and treat all persons equally under the law.

Deuteronomy 1:19

Kadesh-barnea, a great oasis with abundant wells and springs, was about fifty miles south of Beersheba, the traditional southern point of Israel (see [2 Sam 3:10](#); [1 Chr 21:2](#)).

Deuteronomy 1:19–25

See [Num 13](#).

Deuteronomy 1:24–25

Eshcol means “cluster”; the fruit grown there was grapes (see [Num 13:23–27](#)).

Deuteronomy 1:26–46

See [Num 14](#).

Deuteronomy 1:28

Anak was a well-known man of gigantic physical stature ([2:10](#), [21](#); [9:2](#); [Num 13:33](#)). Goliath ([1 Sam 17:4](#)) might have been one of the descendants of Anak who migrated to the Philistine coastal plain ([Deut 2:23](#); [Josh 11:21–23](#); [15:14](#); [1 Chr 20:4–8](#)).

Deuteronomy 1:30

He will fight for you: This phrase refers to the defeat of the Canaanite nations. The Lord would initiate the battle, lead it, fight it, and bring it to a successful conclusion. The only other use of this phrase refers to God’s activity in the Exodus ([Exod 14:14](#)).

Deuteronomy 1:31

God's tender care as a father reflected his covenant relationship with Israel ([Exod 4:22](#); [Hos 11:1-4](#); cp. [Matt 6:26-33](#); [John 14:21](#); [Acts 13:18](#); [Rom 8:15-17](#); [1 Pet 1:2-3](#); [1 Jn 3:1](#)). Israel was God's child by descent from Abraham and because God had chosen and adopted Israel from among all the nations ([Deut 14:2](#); [Exod 19:4-6](#)). The imagery is similar to that found in secular covenant texts in which a great king regarded a vassal with whom he had made a treaty as his son.

Deuteronomy 1:33

Physical manifestations of God (called *theophanies*), such as the pillar of fire and the pillar of cloud, assured God's people of his presence and power. As he moved forward by these visible displays, they could also move, knowing that he would faithfully lead them to their final destination ([Exod 13:21-22](#); [14:24](#); [Ps 18:9-10](#)).

Deuteronomy 1:36

Caleb was one of the twelve spies whom Moses sent to discern the political and military situation in Canaan. Caleb and Joshua alone brought back the report that God would give Israel success in conquering Canaan ([Num 13:6](#), [8](#), [16](#), [30](#)). Caleb later became the father-in-law of Othniel, Israel's first judge ([Judg 1:13](#)). For his faithfulness, Caleb was given the vicinity of Hebron as his inheritance, and he expelled the Anakites (see [Josh 14:12-15](#); [Judg 1:20](#)).

Deuteronomy 1:37

God was angry with me because of you: In his frustration against rebellious Israel, Moses had disobeyed God by striking the rock rather than merely speaking to it ([Num 20:10-13](#)).

Deuteronomy 1:44

Hormah is perhaps modern Khirbet el-Meshash, a site seven miles southeast of Beersheba. The ancient name is derived from the verb *kharam*, which means to "devastate" or "annihilate." The

Israelites indeed devastated Hormah ([Num 14:45](#); [21:3](#)).

Deuteronomy 2:1

Mount Seir was a mountainous territory north of the Gulf of Aqaba, east of the Arabah (see study note on 1:1) and the Dead Sea. It was originally settled by the Horites ([Gen 14:6](#)), now identified by many scholars as the Hurrians. The Hurrians are described in many ancient texts as wandering tradesmen and adventurers who found a home in many parts of the ancient Near East. In time, the Horites of Mount Seir were supplanted by the descendants of Esau ([Deut 2:22](#)), and the region was called Edom ("red"), perhaps because of the rose-red stone typical of the area.

Deuteronomy 2:2-25

[Num 21:10-20](#) covers the same time period.

Deuteronomy 2:5

I have given them: God's gift of a promised land was not limited to Israel. He also distributed lands to Edom, Moab ([2:9](#)), Ammon ([2:19](#)), and the Caphtorites ([2:22-23](#)). Although God had chosen Israel as a special nation ([1:31](#); see also [7:6](#); [14:2](#); [Exod 19:5](#)), he is also the God of all nations and has a place and purpose for each ([Deut 32:8](#); [Acts 17:26](#))—even for those that do not recognize his sovereignty ([Rom 1:16-23](#)).

Deuteronomy 2:8

our relatives: Isaac had two sons, Esau, the firstborn, and Jacob, who obtained Esau's birthright and blessing as the firstborn ([Gen 25:27-34](#); [27:1-36](#)). The result was intense hostility between Esau and Jacob and between their descendants. Israel still recognized and honored the kinship, however; out of fraternal good faith, if not affection, Israel bypassed Edom and did not engage the Edomites in battle (see [Num 20:14-21](#)).

- Arabah Valley: See study note on Deut 1:1.
- Elath and Ezion-geber were twin port cities on the Red Sea. They later harbored the merchant ships of Solomon ([1 Kgs 9:26](#)), Jehoshaphat ([1 Kgs 22:48](#)), and Uzziah ([2 Kgs 14:22](#)).

Deuteronomy 2:9

Following the destruction of Sodom, Gomorrah, and the other cities of the plain, Lot (Abraham's nephew and Isaac's cousin) and his two unmarried daughters sheltered in a cave east of the Dead Sea (see [Gen 19:30-38](#)), where Lot's daughters plied their father with drink until he had sexual relations with them. Their descendants became the nations of Moab and Ammon. Because of their kinship with Israel, the Moabites were to be left undisturbed. David's great-grandmother Ruth descended from Moab ([Ruth 1:4](#)), and David sent his own family to the land of Moab for protection when he was pursued by Saul ([1 Sam 22:3-5](#)). • Ar was probably the capital of Moab.

Deuteronomy 2:10

The Emmites were also located at Shaveh-kiriathaim ([Gen 14:5](#)), perhaps ten miles east of the Dead Sea's north end.

Deuteronomy 2:11

The Rephaites lived near Ashteroth-karnaim ([Gen 14:5](#); perhaps modern Tell Ashtarah), due east of the Sea of Galilee (see [Deut 1:4](#)).

Deuteronomy 2:12

just as Israel drove out: The Hebrew does not include the phrase the people of Canaan. This passage is often cited as a later addition to Deuteronomy because it seems to presuppose the conquest under Joshua. However, it refers in part to the defeat of peoples east of the Jordan, such as the Amorites under King Sihon and King Og ([3:12-17](#)).

Deuteronomy 2:13

The ravine of Zered Brook marked the boundary between Moab and Edom. Rising in the highlands of Mount Seir, this waterway empties into the southeast bend of the Dead Sea.

Deuteronomy 2:19

Like the Moabites, the Ammonites were descendants of the incestuous relationship between Lot and his daughters (see study note on 2:9). Throughout most of their history, the Ammonites lived south and east of the Jabbok River. The nation's capital was Rabbath Ammon (modern Amman, Jordan). David arranged for Uriah, Bathsheba's husband, to be slain in the siege of this city ([2 Sam 11:1, 14-21](#)).

Deuteronomy 2:20-21

The Zamzummites are probably the same as the Zuzites ([Gen 14:5](#)). The Lord had removed them from the land in the past so that the Ammonites could occupy their lands. The God of Israel is also the God of all the earth; he is mindful of all nations and has a place and purpose for each.

Deuteronomy 2:23

The Caphtorites were descendants of Ham and were originally from Crete, a large island south of the Greek peninsula. The Caphtorites are usually identified with the Philistines (see [Gen 10:6-14](#); [1 Chr 1:8-12](#)). The Philistine presence in Canaan resulted from two separate movements, one in the time of the Hebrew patriarchs (see study note on Gen 21:32) and another that began about 1200 BC (see study notes on Josh 13:2; Judg 3:3). This passage apparently refers to the earlier settlement. • The Avvites were indigenous inhabitants of the lower Mediterranean coastal plain; they were supplanted in Gaza by the early wave of Philistines (cp. [Josh 13:2-4](#)).

Deuteronomy 2:24

The Arnon Gorge is the deep canyon formed by the Arnon River; it sometimes marked the border between Moab and Edom (see [Num 21:13](#)). It rises deep in the Arabian Desert and empties into the Dead Sea midway along its eastern shore. • Sihon the Amorite controlled the area east of the Jordan, north of the Arnon, and south of the Ammonite territories (see [Num 21:21-35](#)). He is not known outside of the Bible. His capital, Heshbon, was probably about fifteen miles southwest of Rabbath

Ammon and is usually identified with the impressive ruins at Tell Hesban.

Deuteronomy 2:26

The wilderness of Kedemoth might refer to the area north of the Arnon Gorge between Dibon and Mattanah ([Josh 13:18](#); [21:37](#)).

Deuteronomy 2:26–37

See [Num 21:21–32](#).

Deuteronomy 2:30

made Sihon stubborn and defiant (literally *had hardened his spirit and strengthened his heart*): Like Pharaoh (see [Exod 7:13](#)), Sihon was incorrigibly unrepentant and thus experienced God's wrath. God knew that any further extension of grace to these rulers would be useless. Mystery surrounds the relationship between statements that people harden their own hearts (e.g., [Exod 7:13](#), [22](#); [8:15](#)) and statements that God hardens people's hearts (e.g., [Exod 4:21](#); [7:3](#); [9:12](#)). What is clear is that God appeals for repentance and is ready to forgive, but when people continually ignore or reject his appeals, they can become incapable of hearing and obeying God (see "Hardened Hearts" Theme Note; [Rom 1:21–28](#); [9:17–24](#)).

Deuteronomy 2:34

completely destroyed (Hebrew *kharam*): The Hebrew term refers to the complete consecration of things or people to the Lord, either by destroying them or by giving them as an offering. The underlying rationale was to maintain the Lord's holiness in the face of pagan idolatry and moral corruption (see also [Lev 27:28–29](#)).

Deuteronomy 2:36

Aroer, on the north rim of the Arnon Gorge three miles from Dibon, marked the southernmost extent of the Amorite kingdom ([3:12](#); [4:48](#); [Josh 12:2](#); [13:9](#), [16](#), [25](#)). • The identity of the town in the gorge is uncertain. • Gilead, famous for its balm and other aromatic spices ([Jer 8:22](#); [46:11](#)), lay north of the

Jabbok River, the northernmost border of the Amorites under Sihon.

Deuteronomy 2:37

Like the Moabites, the Ammonites were related to Israel and were thus to be left undisturbed (cp. [2:9](#)). • The Jabbok River, a great tributary of the Jordan River, marked the border between Gilead to the north and the Amorite kingdom of Sihon to the south. The Ammonites lived east and south of the Jabbok ([2:19](#)). It was somewhere at the Jabbok that Jacob wrestled with the stranger at night ([Gen 32:22–32](#)).

Deuteronomy 3:1–11

See [Num 21:33–35](#).

Deuteronomy 3:4

Argob might be synonymous with Bashan or might refer to a heavily populated part of Bashan.

Deuteronomy 3:8

Mount Hermon is the southernmost peak in the Anti-Lebanon Mountains northeast of the Sea of Galilee; at 9,300 feet above sea level, it is also the highest. On a clear day, this impressive landmark is visible from many miles away.

Deuteronomy 3:9

The alternative names Sirion and Senir suggest that Hermon was perhaps a later name given by the Israelites. Hermon is apparently related to the verb *kharam*, which means "to destroy" (see study note on 2:34), and perhaps describes the destruction summarized in [3:3–7](#).

Deuteronomy 3:11

His bed was probably wooden, inlaid with iron. Alternatively, the Hebrew word might suggest a sarcophagus or coffin. • Rabbah is the same city as Rabbath Ammon (see study note on Deut 2:19).

Apparently there was some kind of museum at Rabbah when Deuteronomy was written, and this artifact could be seen there.

Deuteronomy 3:12

The tribes of Reuben and Gad had asked Moses to let them settle east of the Jordan rather than in Canaan, and he allowed them to do so ([Num 32:1–5](#)). • Aroer: See study note on Deut 2:36.

Deuteronomy 3:12–20

See [Num 32](#).

Deuteronomy 3:13

The half-tribe of Manasseh made the same request as Reuben and Gad ([3:12](#)), and Moses accepted their request. Gad and Reuben settled between the Arnon (see [2:24](#)) and the middle of Gilead (see [2:36](#)), and Manasseh took everything north of that, including Bashan (see [3:1](#)). • The Rephaites, a giant people related to the Anakites (see [2:11](#)), are noted here as being indigenous to Bashan.

Deuteronomy 3:14

Jair was a descendant of Manasseh from Makir and Gilead ([1 Chr 2:22](#)). • Geshurites and Maacathites, kingdoms of Bashan, lay along the west side of the Golan Heights, east of the Sea of Galilee. • The Towns of Jair was the name given Argob (see [Deut 3:4](#)) after Jair brought it under Israelite control.

Deuteronomy 3:15

Makir was a clan in the tribe of Manasseh ([Num 26:29](#)) to which Jair was related ([1 Chr 2:21–23](#)). The clan of Makir settled south of Bashan in the northern part of Gilead (see [Deut 3:13](#)).

Deuteronomy 3:17

from the Sea of Galilee down to the Dead Sea: The Hebrew name for the beautiful Sea of Galilee is kinnereth, which might come from kinnor (“harp”)

because of its shape. • The Dead Sea (Hebrew yam hammelakh, “Salt Sea”), here also called the Sea of the Arabah (see study note on 1:1), has a very high mineral content (about 30 percent). • Pisgah is a section of the Abarim mountain range; its most prominent peak is Mount Nebo, where Moses died (see [34:1](#)).

Deuteronomy 3:21

He will do the same: Israel’s military success under Moses’ leadership could be expected to continue under Joshua because the Lord promised to remain with them.

Deuteronomy 3:21–29

See [Num 20:2–13](#); [Ps 106:32–33](#).

Deuteronomy 3:24

Is there any god? Moses did not believe that other gods existed; he was simply affirming that only the Lord is God. Nothing and no one else, real or imaginary, can rival the one true God.

Deuteronomy 3:29

Beth-peor, otherwise known as Baal-peor (see [4:3](#)) or simply Peor ([Num 23:28](#); [Josh 22:17](#)), became Moses’ burial place ([Deut 34:6](#)). At that place the false prophet Balaam had earlier attempted to curse Israel on behalf of Balak, king of Moab ([Num 23:27–24:25](#)).

Deuteronomy 4:1

The pairing of the terms decrees and regulations in Deuteronomy (e.g., [4:5](#), [8](#), [14](#), [45](#); [5:1](#), [31](#)) is a way of referring to the covenant stipulations and the detailed application of the great principles of the Law (see study note on 4:44).

Deuteronomy 4:1–40

Moses’ lengthy exhortation to the Israelite community was based on the people’s recent

failures and his anticipation of what lay ahead in Canaan.

Deuteronomy 4:3

Baal was the Canaanite god associated with the fertility of the soil and of human and animal life. Local pagan worship centers linked Baal with their own shrines and cultic rituals, as with the god of Peor (see [3:29](#)).

Deuteronomy 4:6

Obey . . . wisdom and intelligence: Wisdom is linked to obedience—obeying the Lord is the essence of wisdom (see [10:12–13](#); [Prov 1:7](#); [9:10](#); [15:33](#)). If God’s people were wise and prudent enough to keep the Lord’s perfect covenant, all the world would marvel.

Deuteronomy 4:8

Israel’s laws were righteous and fair because they originated with God.

Deuteronomy 4:11

flames . . . clouds: In these contrasting displays of God’s presence (*theophanies*; see study note on 1:33), he revealed himself while also remaining hidden (see [Exod 19:16–19](#)).

Deuteronomy 4:13

The covenant is the key theological idea of Deuteronomy and perhaps of the entire Old Testament. A covenant was a legal arrangement involving two or more parties who entered into agreements with mutually binding obligations. The covenant at Sinai ([Exod 20–23](#)) codified this relationship between the Lord and Israel; in Deuteronomy, Moses interpreted and expanded the covenant for the new generation that was about to conquer and occupy the Promised Land. • The Ten Commandments (literally *the ten words*, “decatalogue”) are so much at the heart of the covenant text and its requirements as to be equated with the covenant. The first four *words* regulate relationship with God, while the last six

regulate human relationships. • two stone tablets: All legal documents, including covenant texts, were copied for the benefit of all involved parties. God had his copy (the stone tablets) laid inside the Ark of the Covenant in the sanctuary (see [Exod 25:16, 21](#); [31:18](#); [40:20](#); cp. [Deut 31:26](#)); Israel’s copy was written in the books of Exodus ([Exod 20:1–17](#)) and Deuteronomy ([Deut 5:6–21](#)).

Deuteronomy 4:15

form: No image could capture the transcendent glory and power of the invisible God ([Neh 9:20](#); [Isa 63:10–14](#); [Zech 4:6](#); [John 4:24](#)). Any *form* of the Lord could become an object of worship in lieu of worshipping God himself.

Deuteronomy 4:16

idol: Idolatry inherently confined the Lord to the artist’s imagination. Israel was not to make idols in the form of any of his creatures ([4:17–18](#)). Idols and images could lead to worship of the creature rather than the Creator ([5:8–9](#); [Rom 1:23–25](#)).

Deuteronomy 4:19

forces of heaven: This phrase refers to the stars and other heavenly bodies, which, like earthly creations, were thought to embody or represent deities. Instead, they are servants of God, named by him to carry out their duties of marking the times and seasons ([Gen 1:14–19](#); [Isa 40:26](#)). • The Lord your God gave them: Rather than worshipping these heavenly bodies, the people of Israel were to recognize that God’s creation was made, among other reasons, to serve humankind ([Gen 1:28](#)).

Deuteronomy 4:20

An iron-smelting furnace was used to refine metal ores and separate the pure metal from the dross. Israel’s trials in Egypt made the Israelites more spiritually and morally pure. • special possession (literally *people of inheritance*): Israel itself was God’s inheritance. This concept is confirmed by the parallel phrase describing Israel as his very own people. As such, the Israelites were now fit to enter, conquer, and occupy the land (cp. [1 Pet 2:9–12](#)).

Deuteronomy 4:24

God does not have the petty human emotion of jealousy. Rather, the phrase jealous God shows that God was asserting his uniqueness and claiming exclusive worship ([6:15](#); [Lev 10:2](#); [Num 16:35](#)). The Hebrew word can be rendered as “jealous” or “zealous.” God zealously protects his own reputation as the universal sovereign.

Deuteronomy 4:26

Heaven and earth would be witnesses against Israel if the people were disloyal to the Lord. In a covenant partnership, the parties to the agreement were held accountable to the oaths of loyalty and commitment they made to each other in the presence of witnesses ([Isa 1:2-7](#); [Mic 6:1-8](#)). In Deuteronomy, the natural creation plays that role of witness (see Deut also [30:19](#)).

Deuteronomy 4:27

scatter you: One of the curses directed against Israel if it violated the terms of the covenant was the dispersion of the people to the ends of the earth ([28:64](#)). This judgment later came to pass repeatedly, especially when the Assyrians occupied the northern kingdom in 722 BC, when the Babylonians conquered Judah in 605-586 BC, and when Jerusalem was destroyed in AD 70.

Deuteronomy 4:30

distant future (literally *last* [or *latter*] *days*): Israel would eventually return from the Exile and worldwide dispersion (see [30:1-10](#); [Lev 26:40-45](#); [Jer 31:27-34](#); [Ezek 36:22-31](#)).

Deuteronomy 4:34

strong hand, a powerful arm: Describing divine qualities in human terms is called *anthropomorphism* (see study note on 8:2). Here it represents God's sovereign power in delivering Israel from bondage in Egypt.

Deuteronomy 4:36

great fire: God revealed the covenant law at Mount Sinai with a magnificent and terrifying display of power and glory comparable to the eruption of a great volcano (see study note on 1:33; see [Exod 3:1-4](#); [24:16-18](#)).

Deuteronomy 4:39

The Lord is unique, and there is no other besides him. This instruction reaffirms the first two commandments ([5:6-8](#); [Exod 20:2-4](#)) and foreshadows the *Shema* ([Deut 6:4-5](#)). God's uniqueness had to be underscored because Israel's neighbors worshiped many gods.

Deuteronomy 4:40

More than a promise of individual longevity, long life described Israel's tenure in the land of promise.

Deuteronomy 4:41-43

When Israel settled in Canaan and adopted an urban lifestyle, crimes such as homicide would inevitably need judicial resolution. In order to protect alleged perpetrators from premature vengeance and to guarantee them a fair trial, they needed safe haven in accessible cities of refuge. These towns were first assigned east of the Jordan and later in Canaan (see [Num 35:9-28](#)). The laws governing these matters occur again in [Deut 19:1-13](#), but they appear here because of the just-mentioned promise of a long and safe life in the land ([4:40](#)). Establishing places of refuge to protect the innocent from false accusations would help secure that promise.

Deuteronomy 4:41-49

Moses was ready to set forth the covenant in all its magisterial authority. This section bridges the review of the past ([1:6-4:40](#)) and the presentation of the covenant text proper ([5:1-26:19](#)).

Deuteronomy 4:43

Bezer (probably modern Umm al-‘Amad) lay some six miles east of Heshbon. • Ramoth in Gilead was thirty-five miles east-southeast of the Sea of Galilee. • The town of Golan was about forty miles north of *Ramoth in Gilead*.

Deuteronomy 4:44

body of instruction (Hebrew *torah*): The Hebrew noun is derived from the verb *yarah*, “to teach”; its basic meaning is instruction. The Greek Old Testament understands the term to mean “law.” In this context, the term introduces the *body of instruction* in the remainder of Deuteronomy (see study note on 5:1–26:19).

Deuteronomy 4:48

Mount Sirion: The Sidonians used the name *Sirion* for Mount Hermon.

Deuteronomy 4:49

conquered the eastern bank of the Jordan River as far south as the Dead Sea (Hebrew *took the Arabah on the east side of the Jordan as far as the sea of the Arabah*): The Arabah (“wilderness” or “wasteland”) usually refers to the Great Rift Valley south of the Dead Sea; in Deuteronomy, it also pertains to the lower Jordan Valley (see [1:1](#); [3:17](#)).

Deuteronomy 5:1

decrees and regulations: These technical terms describe the stipulations that Israel must obey as the junior partner in the covenant.

Deuteronomy 5:1–32

The rest of the covenant laws expand and comment upon the Ten Commandments ([5:6–21](#)), on which they are based. Moses had first given the Ten Commandments to the people of Israel nearly forty years earlier ([Exod 20:2–17](#)).

Deuteronomy 5:1–26.19

This section contains the heart of the covenant document, the stipulations. The first subdivision ([5:1–11:32](#)) sets forth the major stipulations relating especially to the first two commandments ([5:7–10](#)). The more specific minor stipulations make up the rest of the section.

Deuteronomy 5:9

The children of sinful parents are not punished for the wrongdoings of their mothers and fathers, but the sins of any generation have consequences that last for generations (see [2 Sam 12:10](#)). • The term reject (literally *hate*) does not relate to having bitter and hostile feelings but to forsaking a relationship.

Deuteronomy 5:10

who love me: Those who choose to accept the Lord do not hate or reject him.

Deuteronomy 5:11

misuse the name (literally *take up the name in vain*): Someone who “takes the name of the Lord in vain” uses it manipulatively to achieve a desired end, uses it thoughtlessly, or takes an oath by God’s name that a falsehood is true.

Deuteronomy 5:12

keeping it holy: Certain holy days were set apart from others and were given extraordinary significance. On the Sabbath day, the community stopped working and worshiped the Lord (cp. [1 Cor 16:2](#); [Heb 10:25](#)).

Deuteronomy 5:15

That is why: God commanded Israel to observe a day of rest to remember that God ceased his work of creation on the seventh day ([Exod 20:11](#)). In Deuteronomy, the Sabbath also celebrated Israel’s release from Egyptian bondage. In the Christian tradition, the first day rather than the seventh is generally set apart to observe the most significant

event in Christian history, the resurrection of Jesus Christ (see study note on Rev 1:10).

Deuteronomy 5:16

Honor: Since parents are representatives of divine authority, children are to recognize them as worthy of obedience and great respect (cp. [Eph 6:1–3](#)).

Deuteronomy 5:16–20

Jesus quoted these five commands in response to the question, “What must I do to inherit eternal life?” ([Matt 19:17–19](#); [Mark 10:19](#); [Luke 18:20](#)).

Deuteronomy 5:17

murder: The Hebrew word can mean either “kill” or “murder.” Killing was permitted in war and as punishment in capital cases, so here it must refer to premeditated homicide. See Jesus’ comments in [Matt 5:21–22](#).

Deuteronomy 5:18

adultery: See Jesus’ comments about adultery in [Matt 5:27–28](#).

Deuteronomy 5:21

covet: This commandment differs from the others because it pertains to a desire rather than to an act. An evil desire is no less offensive to God than an evil deed (see [Matt 5:27–28](#)).

Deuteronomy 5:33

Stay on the path: This figure of speech compares the course of life to making a journey. Israel was called to live in such a way that the nation would not be sidetracked from the purposes for which it had been chosen and equipped.

Deuteronomy 6:1

Moses added commands to decrees and regulations, the usual formula for covenant stipulations (see [4:1](#); [5:1](#)); *commands* is a general term for the whole body of instruction.

Deuteronomy 6:1–25

Moses here explains how the stipulations in the following sections should be applied and handed on to future generations.

Deuteronomy 6:2

God’s awesome power and glory (see [4:10](#)) require that God’s people fear him, treating him with respect and reverence (see study notes on 7:21; 10:12–13).

Deuteronomy 6:3

The milk and honey abundant in Canaan represented both agriculture and forage. Compared to the desert fare, Canaan’s food was sumptuous indeed (see [Exod 3:8, 17](#)).

Deuteronomy 6:4

The Lord is our God, the Lord alone: Only God is worthy of worship ([5:7](#)).

Deuteronomy 6:4–5

Listen (Hebrew *shema*): The *Shema* is the fundamental statement of Israel’s faith. Jesus described these verses as the greatest of the commandments ([Matt 22:34–39](#); [Mark 12:28–31](#); [Luke 10:25–28](#)), a sentiment shared by ancient and modern Judaism. The rabbi Hillel (first century BC) spoke of the *Shema* as the central theological idea of the Hebrew Bible (the Old Testament), calling the rest mere commentary.

Deuteronomy 6:5

love the Lord: See study note on Josh 23:11. • The words heart, . . . soul, and . . . strength represent the

intellect, the will, the emotions, the spirituality, and the physical being—all that a person is and can do for God. This commandment is the core of God's covenant with Israel (see Jesus' comments in [Matt 22:37](#); [Mark 12:30](#); [Luke 10:27](#)).

Deuteronomy 6:7

Repeat them: The Hebrew verb (*shanan*) might suggest “engraving” a text into a medium that cannot be obliterated, or it might simply mean “repeat.” Either way, the teaching of the *Shema* was to be indelibly imparted to children by constant repetition so that it would never be forgotten.

Deuteronomy 6:8

Tie them: The Lord's commandments ([6:6](#)) were to be as interwoven into the hearts and minds of children as though they were tied to them. Eventually, this figurative phrase in Judaism was practiced literally by wrapping the forearm with cords representing the Torah (see study note on 4:44). • wear them: This figure of speech was represented literally in later Judaism by a small box containing a few brief Torah texts. The box and its contents (Hebrew *tefillin*; Greek *phylactery*) were reminders of the need to teach and obey the covenant (cp. [11:18](#); [Matt 23:5](#)).

Deuteronomy 6:9

Write them on the doorposts: In later Judaism, people placed portions of Deuteronomy in a small metal case (a *mezuzah*) attached to the doorframes of houses or other buildings. It was customary to touch the *mezuzah* when passing through the doorway to show respect for and dependence upon the Scripture.

Deuteronomy 6:13

Jesus quoted this verse when tempted by Satan ([Matt 4:10](#); [Luke 4:8](#)).

Deuteronomy 6:16

When Israel journeyed through the Sinai desert after the Exodus, they came to Rephidim, where

they found no water ([Exod 17:1–7](#)). Moses saw the people's demand for water as testing the Lord; hence the name Massah (“testing”) for this place. Jesus quoted this verse to rebut Satan ([Matt 4:7](#); [Luke 4:12](#)).

Deuteronomy 6:21

The phrase his strong hand is an anthropomorphism (see study note on 8:2).

Deuteronomy 6:22

The signs and wonders were the ten plagues God sent to impress Israel and Egypt with his power when he brought about the Exodus ([Exod 7–12](#); see also [Exod 3:20](#); [4:5](#); [Josh 4:23–24](#)).

Deuteronomy 6:25

righteous when we obey: Obedience shows that one is already in a state of righteousness, a standing before God obtained by faith (see [24:13](#); [Hab 2:4](#); [Rom 1:17](#); [4:1–5](#); [Gal 3:6–7](#); see also [Gen 15:6](#); [Eph 2:8–9](#)). When other nations observed Israel's commitment to the covenant, they could rightly conclude that Israel was righteous.

Deuteronomy 7:1

The Hittites were native to Anatolia (now north-central Turkey). They established colonies in far-flung areas such as Syria and were also linked to Canaan in the list of ancient nations (see [Gen 10:15](#); [23:3–20](#)). The Hittite empire came to a sudden end around 1200 BC, but people known as Hittites continued to live in Israel (e.g., Uriah the Hittite, [2 Sam 11:3](#); [23:39](#)). It is impossible to prove that the Hittites of Anatolia were the same as those mentioned in the OT, but some commonality is probable. • Gergashites were an otherwise unknown Canaanite people ([Gen 10:16–17](#)). • Amorites: See study note on Deut 1:4. • The Canaanites were the native people of Canaan; their habitation there can be traced back to 3000 BC. They descended from Noah's son Ham (see [Gen 9:18–27](#)). • The Perizzites are not listed in the Table of Nations ([Gen 10:16–17](#)), so they might not have been related to the Canaanites. • Many scholars identify the Hivites as the Horites (or

Hurrians; see study note on Deut 2:1), a non-Semitic people found throughout the ancient Near East. • The Jebusites were associated with Jerusalem ([Judg 1:21](#); [2 Sam 5:6-8](#)). David bought a piece of land from Araunah the Jebusite to build an altar ([2 Sam 24:15-25](#)); this property later became the site of the Temple ([2 Chr 3:1](#)).

Deuteronomy 7:1-26

Before Israel could occupy the land of promise (cp. [Gen 13:14-17](#); [15:18-21](#)), the nations already living there had to be removed. The land was the Lord's, and only he could determine who the inhabitants should be.

Deuteronomy 7:5

Engraved stone pillars called *stelae* usually represented pagan male deities. These sacred pillars were commonly found at shrines dedicated to Baal. • Asherah poles, usually made of wood, represented Canaanite fertility goddesses, particularly Asherah, the mother of the gods. These shrines might have developed as stylized sacred trees associated with fertility (see study note on 12:2).

Deuteronomy 7:6

Of all peoples on earth, God chose Israel as his special treasure. Israel had not done anything commendable; rather, God acted out of grace that was undeserved and freely given.

Deuteronomy 7:9

A faithful God is absolutely dependable and can be leaned upon. Abraham was commended as being righteous because he believed God; he was wholly dependent upon God's faithfulness ([Gen 15:6](#)). • Contrasted with human agents, who often break their pledges, the Lord faithfully keeps his covenant.

Deuteronomy 7:12

promised with an oath (literally *swore*): In a covenant or treaty, the parties to the covenant had

to swear to keep its terms in order for it to be valid. God's promises are always guaranteed by his character ([7:9](#); [32:4](#); [Heb 6:18](#); [Jas 1:17](#)). He fulfilled the requirements of the covenant with Israel by swearing to keep its terms (see [Gen 22:16](#)).

Deuteronomy 7:15

The terrible diseases . . . in Egypt were perhaps illnesses related to the plagues (e.g., [Exod 9:9](#)) or other serious diseases that regularly afflicted the Egyptians.

Deuteronomy 7:19

The familiar word pair signs and wonders signifies the miraculous deeds God performed to induce fear in his enemies and to inspire awe and praise in his people (see [6:22](#)). • strong hand and powerful arm: See study notes on 4:34 and 8:2.

Deuteronomy 7:20

terror: Often rendered *the hornet*. Whether God sent stinging insects or some other source of terror, he would expel surviving Canaanites from the land ([Exod 23:28](#); [Josh 24:12](#)).

Deuteronomy 7:21

awesome (literally *one to be feared*): This fear is not the terror induced by a bully who strikes without reason or plan, but the reverential fear of a loving God whose nature is so majestic that it inspires a kind of dread.

Deuteronomy 7:24

erase their names: An individual's name represented that person's existence as it would be carried into the future through generations of descendants. By destroying an entire nation, God cut off its line of descent and thus also its future. The Canaanites who suffered God's war against them lost all their descendants and thus their existence and identity.

Deuteronomy 7:25-26

Worship of false gods is detestable to the Lord: It denies that God is unique and rejects his demand for exclusive worship ([5:7-9](#)). The horrific and disgusting rituals typically associated with pagan worship were antithetical to God's holy nature, but Israel was in danger of being led into similar beliefs and practices ([12:31](#); [13:12-17](#)). An Israelite who acknowledged false gods committed an act of treason. The only remedy was complete and total destruction of these detestable objects.

Deuteronomy 7:26

set apart for destruction (Hebrew *kherem*): See study note on 2:34.

Deuteronomy 8:1-20

Once Israel inhabited the land, they might have the human tendency to take credit for the blessings that followed. Moses warned the people to guard against a self-congratulatory attitude. God alone is the source of all prosperity and achievement.

Deuteronomy 8:2

to prove your character (literally *to know what is in your heart*): God already knew the Israelites' innermost thoughts ([Pss 51:6](#); [139:1](#), [4](#), [23](#)); he wanted their character to come out in their actions.

- to find out whether: The Old Testament often describes God in human terms, even in ways that appear to limit God. *Anthropomorphism* (assigning human characteristics to God) and *anthropopathism* (assigning human feelings or emotions to God) are ways of representing God on a human level so the human mind can better grasp his ways, but God is not limited in his knowledge, power, or transcendence. Here, God is figuratively described as having only a human knowledge of the future, but other passages make it clear that God knows everything—past, present, and future ([Ps 139:1-18](#); [Heb 4:13](#)).

Deuteronomy 8:3

The word *manna* is derived from the Hebrew words *man hu* (meaning "what is it?"). God

miraculously provided this food to teach his people total dependence on him ([Exod 16:1-30](#); [Num 11:4-9](#)). Manna represented the word of God, which is even more essential to life and well-being than food is. • people do not live by bread alone: Jesus quoted this phrase to rebut Satan ([Matt 4:4](#); [Luke 4:4](#)).

Deuteronomy 8:9

Iron was not widely used in this period of the Bronze Age because the process of smelting and working it was known to only a few cultures (see [1 Sam 13:19-21](#)). The time would come when Israel would exploit this vastly superior metal (see [Josh 17:16-18](#); [1 Kgs 6:7](#); [2 Kgs 6:5](#); [1 Chr 22:3](#)).

Deuteronomy 8:15

water from the rock! See [Exod 17:6](#); [Num 20:2-13](#); see also [Deut 1:37](#).

Deuteronomy 8:18

This was not the covenant that God made with the previous generation of Israelites at Sinai but the one he first made with Abraham ([Gen 15:1-21](#); [17:1-21](#)), then Isaac ([Gen 26:1-5](#)) and Jacob ([Gen 28:1-4](#), [13-15](#); [46:1-4](#)). • In order to be legal and proper, a covenant had to be sworn to with an oath that all parties to the agreement uttered. Although by his very nature God could never rescind a promise, he honored the protocol (see [Deut 7:12](#)).

Deuteronomy 9:1

walls that reach to the sky: This figurative language emphasizes the impossibility of breaching these walls by human effort alone ([Num 13:28](#)). If Israel were to enjoy success, God must lead the way and fight the battle ([Deut 9:5](#)).

Deuteronomy 9:3

The graphic metaphor like a devouring fire depicts God's war against his enemies (see [1:30](#)). God will not just use fire but will himself be a raging inferno, consuming everything in his path. In the end, Israel

would simply have to step in and occupy the subdued land.

Deuteronomy 9:5

to fulfill the oath: In the covenant promises made to the patriarchs, God swore that their descendants would inherit the land of Canaan ([Gen 13:14–17](#); [15:18–21](#); see [Deut 1:8](#); [8:18](#)).

Deuteronomy 9:6

Stubborn (literally *stiff-necked*) describes a draft animal that is unwilling to bend its neck to the yoke ([Exod 32:9](#); [33:3](#), [5](#); [Isa 48:4](#)). Sadly, Israel was not just occasionally stubborn; stubbornness was the nation's characteristic behavior and attitude.

Deuteronomy 9:9

Covenant here refers to the promises God made with Israel nearly forty years earlier at Sinai (see [4:13](#)). • The common biblical expression forty days and forty nights represents trial or testing ([Exod 34:28](#)). Moses' fast was like Jesus' fast ([Matt 4:2](#)). It is physically possible to go without food for forty days, but a person cannot ordinarily survive without water for more than a few days. Moses was directly sustained by God (cp. [Matt 4:11](#)).

Deuteronomy 9:10

Speaking of God's own finger (see study notes on [4:34](#) and [8:2](#)) emphasizes God's personal interest and involvement in communicating the text of the covenant ([Exod 31:18](#); [32:15–16](#); [34:1](#), [28](#)).

Deuteronomy 9:12

The type of idol (from a Hebrew word meaning *cast* or *pour*) mentioned here was formed by pouring liquid metal into a mold ([Exod 32:1–4](#)). Other idols were made of carved wood, stone, clay, or precious metals hammered in thin sheets over wooden cores.

Deuteronomy 9:14

erase their name: The Lord threatened to destroy Israel's identity and existence (see study note on [7:24](#)).

Deuteronomy 9:16

The gold calf idol Israel made at Sinai ([Exod 32](#)) was probably modeled after bovine deities of Egypt, such as the bull god Apis and the cow goddess Hathor, both associated with fertility. When the Israelites entered Canaan, they would be confronted with the fertility gods of the Canaanite cults. They would be tempted to rely upon these false gods, rather than the one true God, as the source of their blessings (cp. [Deut 8:18–20](#)).

Deuteronomy 9:22

Shortly after Israel left Sinai, the people began to murmur against the Lord so incessantly and bitterly that he sent a fiery judgment to slay some of them at Taberah (Taberah means "place of burning"). • Even earlier, the people came to Massah, a place where they tested the Lord to see whether he could supply their need for water (*Massah* means "place of testing"). • At Kibroth-hattaavah, the Israelites demanded food other than manna. The Lord miraculously provided quail, with which they gorged themselves. Many of them paid for this sin of gluttony with their lives. *Kibroth-hattaavah* means "graves of gluttony."

Deuteronomy 9:23

Israel made Kadesh-barnea its major headquarters for the thirty-eight years of wandering in the wilderness (see also study note on [1:19](#)).

Deuteronomy 9:26

The Lord redeemed Israel from their bondage in Egypt by his own gracious efforts on their behalf.

Deuteronomy 9:27

In Hebrew, the term translated remember does not always mean to recall something that has been

forgotten, especially when God is the subject (see study notes on 8:2 and 32:36). Here the meaning is that God would honor the promises he made to the patriarchs by doing what he said he would do. Appealing to God to remember goes beyond urging him to be aware of a need; it is a petition for him to act in the face of that need (cp. [Luke 23:42–43](#)).

Deuteronomy 10:1

The Ark was a gold-plated wooden chest that contained the stone tablets; it was kept in the Most Holy Place in the Tabernacle or Temple ([Exod 25:10](#)). Later, a pot of manna and Aaron's flowering rod were also placed in the Ark ([Heb 9:4](#)). The Ark was the throne upon which the invisible Lord sat on earth among his people (see study notes on Exod 25:22 and Lev 16:2).

Deuteronomy 10:3

acacia wood: This durable desert tree is probably the species *Acacia raddiana*; it is the only variety that grows large enough in the Negev to produce timber for building.

Deuteronomy 10:5

still there: Occasionally, phrases such as this one appear in Deuteronomy, indicating that the book received final touches sometime after Moses originally composed it. At the time the book was finally edited, the stone tablets were still in the Ark.

Deuteronomy 10:12–13

fear the Lord your God: The fear of God is not terror from dread of his wrath. Rather, God wanted his people to recognize their finiteness and unworthiness in his divine presence (see study notes on 7:21 and Prov 1:7).

Deuteronomy 10:16

change your hearts (literally *circumcise the foreskin of your hearts*): This figure of speech encompasses both inward and outward conformity to the covenant ([Gen 17:9–14](#); [Rom 2:28–29](#)).

Deuteronomy 10:17

The phrase God of gods does not affirm the existence of other gods; rather, it affirms God's absolute sovereignty over all powers in heaven and earth. The Hebrew 'elohim, translated gods, can also refer to angels or other powerful beings (see [Ps 82:1](#)). • shows no partiality: God is not impressed with people who hold power and influence, and therefore he offers them no privileged consideration (see [Deut 1:17](#)).

Deuteronomy 10:18

foreigners (literally *sojourners*): "A rabble of non-Israelites" ([Exod 12:38](#)) came out of Egypt with the Israelites, and others later took up residence in Israel for various reasons. Some of these non-Israelites had no intention of becoming part of the covenant nation, but other foreigners, while not citizens of Israel, were God-fearers or potential proselytes. They lacked full equality with the Israelites and thus were often victims of neglect and discrimination.

Deuteronomy 11:4

The common translation Red Sea (literally *sea of reeds*) comes from the Greek Old Testament. It was called the "Sea of Reeds" because of the marshy plants that grew along its shores.

Deuteronomy 11:6

Dathan and Abiram: See [Num 16:1–40](#). In the Lord's administration of his kingdom, he established levels of authority and command that were not to be transgressed. Because the Lord had appointed Moses and Aaron as leaders, the rebellion of Dathan and Abiram against Moses was the same as rebellion against God's sovereign rule.

Deuteronomy 11:8–32

Moses here appends to the covenant stipulations (chs [5–11](#)) a list of curses and blessings similar to those that follow the whole covenant text in chs [27–28](#).

Deuteronomy 11:12

a land . . . your God cares for: God's care included blessing the land with all the resources his people would need to survive and prosper there.

Deuteronomy 11:24

you set foot (literally *you tread the sole of your foot*): This idea suggests claiming a territory by placing a foot on it or walking through it (see [Gen 13:17](#); [Josh 1:3](#); [14:9](#)).

Deuteronomy 11:26

In covenant contexts, a blessing is the outcome of obedience, while a curse is the result of disobedience (see chs [27–28](#)).

Deuteronomy 11:29

Mount Gerizim is a prominent hill lying just west of Shechem. In later times, the Samaritans built a temple there (cp. [John 4:20](#)). • Mount Ebal is across the valley from Mount Gerizim, to the east of Shechem.

Deuteronomy 11:30

Gilgal was the site of the first camp the Israelites would make in Canaan after crossing the Jordan ([Josh 4:19](#)). It was about two miles northeast of Jericho, although its exact location is no longer certain. A line from Jericho to Shechem would pass near Gilgal. • The oaks of Moreh were near Shechem; they were where Abram had set up his first camp in Canaan ([Gen 12:6](#)) and where Jacob had later buried Laban's idols ([Gen 35:4](#)).

Deuteronomy 12:1–26.15

After Moses laid out the principles of the covenant ([5:1–11:32](#)), he moved to the application of these principles in everyday life. Passages in this section expand on the Ten Commandments and cover some of the contingencies that inevitably arise in the complexity of human relationships.

Deuteronomy 12:2

green tree: The Canaanites selected groves of trees for worship sites because their lush foliage demonstrated fertility. Sometimes trees were stylized in the form of wooden poles driven into the ground and dedicated to the worship of the mother goddess, Asherah (see [7:5](#)).

Deuteronomy 12:3

sacred pillars: See study note on 7:5. • Asherah poles: The feminine counterpart to the sacred pillar was a wooden pole dedicated to the mother goddess, Asherah. • erase the names: With the destruction of all idols and every vestige of pagan worship, the names of these deities would be forgotten. Future generations would know nothing of them (see also study note on 7:24).

Deuteronomy 12:5

his name will be honored: The name of the Lord represents the Lord himself. God lived among his people in a designated location by placing his name there (see [Exod 3:13–14](#)).

Deuteronomy 12:6

All of the offerings listed here are expressions of thanksgiving, fellowship, and loyalty to the Lord. In covenant relationships, the vassal offered tribute to the great king as a sign of submission and a promise of dependability (see study note on 1:31).

Deuteronomy 12:8

doing as you please: Until the Exodus, the Israelites probably worshiped at multiple shrines in Egypt. With the construction of the Tabernacle, worship was centralized and remained so with the later building of the Temple. In the future, the community would be required to assemble on stated occasions to worship the Lord collectively at the central sanctuary, although local worship by individuals, families, and even villages would continue (see [Exod 20:24–26](#); [1 Sam 9:11–14](#)).

Deuteronomy 12:12

The Levites, descendants of Jacob's son Levi, were set apart to serve the Lord full time in Israel's religious life ([Num 18:1-7](#)). The primary task of the Levites was to assist the priests in their various responsibilities. Because the priests and the Levites could not engage in secular pursuits, they depended on the generosity of Israel's other tribes for their livelihood ([Num 18:21-24](#)).

Deuteronomy 12:15

butcher your animals . . . whenever you want: This instruction refers to animals for eating, not for a ritual sacrifice. • ceremonially clean or unclean: The slaughter of animals for food could take place without the slayer undergoing the purification rituals necessary when sacrificial animals were slain.

Deuteronomy 12:16

The prohibition against consuming blood pertained both to sacrificial animals and to those slain for meat. Because it represented life, blood was sacred and was to be rendered only to God. This principle is inherent in creation and preceded the law ([Gen 4:10-11](#); [9:4-6](#); [Lev 17:11](#)). See also study note on [Lev 7:26-27](#).

Deuteronomy 12:18

The place he will choose was the central sanctuary—first the Tabernacle and then the Temple.

Deuteronomy 12:21

you may butcher: Because an animal's blood was considered sacred (see [Gen 9:4-6](#)), even meat intended for human consumption was to be slaughtered at the central designated place of worship if that was at all practical (cp. [Lev 17:8-9](#)); if not, the animal could be sacrificed locally, but the blood still had to be disposed of in a ritually appropriate manner ([Deut 12:23-25](#); cp. [Lev 17:10-12](#)).

Deuteronomy 12:23

the blood is the life: In this figure of speech, the means (blood) is equated with the effect (life). Since life is sacred, its vehicle, the blood, is also sacred (see also [Lev 17:11](#)).

Deuteronomy 12:27

you may eat the meat: The exception was meat sacrificed in burnt offerings, which was to be given to the Lord and wholly consumed in the fire (see [Lev 1:3-17](#) and study note).

Deuteronomy 12:31

burn their sons and daughters: Human sacrifice was one of the most abhorrent practices of ancient pagan religions. The Ammonites believed that their god Molech required such sacrifice from his worshipers ([Lev 18:21](#); [20:2](#); [2 Kgs 23:10](#); [Jer 32:35](#)).

Deuteronomy 13:1

God performed signs and miracles to induce amazement and faith in those who witnessed them (see [6:22](#)). False prophets and magicians were able to replicate these feats to a degree and thus sometimes led God's people astray (see [Exod 7:11, 22](#); [8:7](#)).

Deuteronomy 13:1-18

Prophets who tried to lead Israel away from the one true God were guilty of treason, which carried the death penalty. No other religion insisted on exclusive worship of their national gods; consequently, such harsh penalties for the worship of competing deities were unknown elsewhere in the ancient Near East.

Deuteronomy 13:5

visionaries: Literally *dreamer of dreams*. • purge (literally *burn*): God wanted false prophets to be completely eliminated, leaving no residue of their evil ways. See also [17:12](#); [19:13](#).

Deuteronomy 13:6

The Israelites had heard of these false gods before, but they had never worshiped them. Doing so would violate the first two commandments, the essence of the covenant.

Deuteronomy 13:9

Strike the first blow yourself: Because the guilty parties would be members of one's own family ([13:6](#)), this difficult demand would test the depth of a person's commitment to worship the Lord exclusively. Love for God must take priority over love for family members and friends ([Matt 10:34-39](#)).

Deuteronomy 13:13

scoundrels (literally *sons of Belial*): In Hebrew, "son(s) of" often expresses group affiliation or shared characteristics. *Scoundrels* typically deceived others and led them astray ([Prov 6:12; 16:27; 19:28; Nah 1:11](#)).

Deuteronomy 13:14

A detestable act is any deed or even thought that is offensive to God (see study notes on 7:25-26; 12:31).

Deuteronomy 13:16

Plunder or "spoils of war" were not to be kept. God had ordered them to be completely destroyed (see [2:34; Leviticus 27:28-29](#)).

Deuteronomy 14:1

- *cut yourselves*: This pagan custom often linked to mourning ceremonies, possibly to try to get the dead to return to life (see [1 Kings 18:28; Zechariah 13:4-6](#)).
- *shave your foreheads*: This practice also related to mourning for the dead (see [Leviticus 19:27-28; 21:5-6](#)). But the exact meaning of this ceremony is unclear.

Deuteronomy 14:1-21

See "Clean, Unclean, and Holy" Theme Note.

Deuteronomy 14:2

The basic Hebrew meaning of *holy* is the separation of a person or thing for a specific purpose. It can also mean "pure" or "morally and spiritually good."

Deuteronomy 14:6

split hooves and chews the cud: These criteria distinguished edible animals listed in [14:4-5](#) from those listed in [14:7-8](#). Although the people experienced health benefits from observing these restrictions, a thing was actually clean or unclean only because God declared it to be such.

Deuteronomy 14:7

The hyrax is a rabbit-sized, hooved mammal.

Deuteronomy 14:8

The instruction not to touch their carcasses was primarily to maintain ritual purity.

Deuteronomy 14:11-18

These animals are grouped as flying animals that eat rotting flesh.

Deuteronomy 14:19–20

winged insects: Cp. [Lev 11:20–23](#).

Deuteronomy 14:21

Animals that had died a natural death were considered unclean (even if considered clean while living) because they had not been slaughtered according to ritual protocol and their blood had not been properly drained and disposed of (see [12:23–25](#)). • You must not cook a young goat in its mother's milk: A common explanation for why this pagan practice was improper is that it displayed insensitivity to the natural feelings of affection and trust between mothers and their offspring (see [28:56–57](#)).

Deuteronomy 14:22–27

set aside a tithe: The ancient practice of giving a tenth preceded the law of Moses ([Gen 14:20; 28:22](#)) and existed in other ancient cultures. Here it is viewed as a tax or tribute collected by the sovereign Lord from his vassals (see study notes on Deut 1:31 and 12:6).

Deuteronomy 14:23

The place the Lord your God chooses for his name to be honored (literally *the place he will cause his name to dwell*) was the central sanctuary, the Lord's dwelling on the earth among his people (see [12:5, 18](#)).

Deuteronomy 14:26

Both wine and other alcoholic drink were used in worship ceremonies ([Gen 14:18; 35:14; Exod 29:40–41; Matt 26:27](#)) and in celebrations; they signified God's blessing ([Gen 27:25, 28; 49:11; 1 Chr 12:40; Ps 104:15; Song 4:10; 5:1; Isa 25:6; Matt 26:29](#)).

Deuteronomy 14:27

Because the Levites had no geographic inheritance of their own and were forbidden to engage in secular work, they depended on the support of other tribes (see [12:12](#)).

Deuteronomy 14:28

An annual tithe was required of all adult Israelite males as part of their festival observances ([15:20; 16:16–17](#)). The tithe every third year met the needs of the Levites and other dependent classes in Israelite society ([14:29](#)). See study note on Lev 27:30.

Deuteronomy 15:1

cancel the debts: This technical term refers to releasing people in financial bondage from their creditors and from any penalty for their default.

Deuteronomy 15:1–23

The Law included the regulation of borrowing and lending so that the poor could survive deprivation. It provided restrictions to allow the rich to minister to the needs of the poor without exploiting them.

Deuteronomy 15:2

The time of release was to occur every seventh year across the nation (the Sabbath year, [Lev 25:1–7](#)). The time frame followed the calendar rather than the length of the loan arrangement. This meant that the year of release could fall as soon as a year after a loan was made.

Deuteronomy 15:4

If Israel lived in perfect obedience to the covenant, there would be no poor in the nation. However, this ideal was never realized in ancient Israel, and poverty was very much an issue.

Deuteronomy 15:6

You will lend money to many nations: An obedient Israel would become an affluent nation able to provide international aid. This bounty would bear testimony to God's promise to Abraham that his seed would be a blessing to all nations ([Gen 12:2-3](#); [17:4-6](#); [26:3-4](#)).

Deuteronomy 15:11

The reality that there will always be some . . . who are poor in a fallen world is no excuse for indifference to their plight. Instead, it should emphasize the need for the rich to contribute to the well-being of the poor ([Matt 26:6-13](#)).

Deuteronomy 15:12

If a fellow Hebrew sells himself or herself to be your servant: This arrangement allowed a debtor to work off financial obligations to a creditor. The limit of this arrangement was seven years (but see [15:16-17](#)).

Deuteronomy 15:16

he loves you: In the context of a covenant, this phrase speaks of a binding relationship with both legal and emotional overtones.

Deuteronomy 15:17

push it through his earlobe: This disfigurement publicly indicated that a bondservant had voluntarily indentured himself to his master for life. This might be what Paul meant when he said "I bear on my body the scars that show I belong to Jesus" ([Gal 6:17](#)).

Deuteronomy 15:18

worth double the wages: Because a bondservant worked all day, every day, his output was more than that of a day laborer, who merely put in his shift.

Deuteronomy 15:19

The firstborn males of livestock represented the firstborn sons of Israel who had been spared from death in the tenth plague ([Exod 12:12, 29](#); [13:2, 12](#); [22:29](#)).

Deuteronomy 15:21

A defect was any imperfection that devalued an animal; it was no sacrifice to give up something that was of little or no worth to begin with ([2 Sam 24:24](#)).

Deuteronomy 15:23

The blood of an animal was seen as synonymous with its life, the most sacred of God's creations, so it was sacrilegious to consume it (see [12:16](#)).

Deuteronomy 16:1-8

The Passover (Hebrew *pesakh*) was the festival marking Israel's deliverance from the tenth plague and from bondage in Egypt (see [Exod 11-12](#); [Lev 23:5-8](#)). • The Exodus was such a significant event in Israel's history that the month of Abib, when the Exodus took place, became the beginning of Israel's annual calendar (see [Exod 12:2](#)).

Deuteronomy 16:2

the place . . . for his name to be honored: The Lord's name represented the Lord himself. When he placed his name in the Tabernacle or Temple, he was effectively taking up residence there (see [12:5, 18](#)).

Deuteronomy 16:3

Although yeast frequently symbolizes corruption ([Lev 6:14-17](#); [Matt 16:11-12](#)), it was avoided at the original Passover because the Israelites had no time to wait for yeast bread to rise (see [Exod 12:10-14](#)). The elements of the yearly Passover celebration reminded the Israelites of what God had done for them.

Deuteronomy 16:10

The Festival of Harvest took place seven weeks after Passover to celebrate the wheat harvest ([Exod 34:22](#); [Lev 23:15-22](#)).

Deuteronomy 16:13-17

The Festival of Shelters is called this because the people of Israel were instructed to camp out for a week in crude huts made of tree limbs as a memorial to their years of wilderness wandering ([Lev 23:33-43](#)). It was also a celebration of the fall harvests.

Deuteronomy 16:16

Participation in the festival was required of every man, but women and children could participate as well ([16:11](#), [14](#); cp. [Luke 2:41](#)).

Deuteronomy 16:18

The combination of the words judges and officials might suggest that here the two terms are functionally synonymous. Usually officials is a generic title applied to any public leader, but here it seems to refer to an administrator of law and justice or something like police officers, as in modern Hebrew. • fairly: The idea was to measure up to an objective standard of equity that neither public nor private pressure could alter.

Deuteronomy 16:18-17:13

The community of Israel, like any political entity, needed leaders of different kinds to provide cohesion and guidance. The Lord directed Moses to establish an appropriate leadership structure. He also laid out the criteria for selecting the leaders and the responsibilities of each office.

Deuteronomy 16:19

show partiality: See study note on 1:16-17.

Deuteronomy 16:21-22

Asherah pole . . . sacred pillars: See study note on 7:5; see also [12:3](#); [Isa 27:8-9](#); [Mic 5:13-15](#).

Deuteronomy 17:1

A sick or defective animal had little monetary value, so it was no sacrifice to surrender it to the Lord (cp. [15:21](#)).

Deuteronomy 17:3

The forces of heaven are visible objects such as the sun, moon, and stars, as well as invisible beings such as angels. Worship of anyone or anything created by God is a clear violation of the second commandment (see [5:9](#)).

Deuteronomy 17:4

Anything offensive to the Lord could be called a detestable thing (see [7:25](#); [12:31](#); [13:14](#)).

Deuteronomy 17:5

the gates: A typical town in ancient Israel was small (about 10 acres or less) and crowded. It had few open areas except for a plaza just inside or outside the main gate where public meetings were held, including trials and other judicial proceedings. The place here is clearly outside of the town because stoning to death would not occur inside the walls ([22:24](#); [1 Kgs 21:10](#)) except under unusual circumstances ([Deut 22:21](#)).

Deuteronomy 17:7

The instruction for witnesses to throw the first stones guarded against unfounded allegations. False testimony carried serious consequences. Requiring a witness to take the leading role in an execution helped guarantee the reliability of his testimony; he would personally bear the guilt if he took the life of an innocent person (see [John 8:1-11](#)). • The people would purge the evil from among you by executing those whose sin brought the stain of guilt upon the community of Israel (see "Purge

the Evil” Theme Note; cp. [1 Cor 5:12–13](#) and study note).

Deuteronomy 17:8

whether someone is guilty of murder or only of manslaughter: In Old Testament law, as in modern jurisprudence, murder was intentional, manslaughter was accidental (cp. [19:1–13](#)).

Deuteronomy 17:9

priests or the judge: Both types of officials could decide matters of either a religious or a secular nature.

Deuteronomy 17:11

do not modify it: This Hebrew term envisions keeping on a straight path (cp. [Prov 4:25–27](#); [Heb 12:13](#)). Once a verdict has been rendered, the sentence must be applied according to the law and the rules of evidence. Justice must be carried out on an unswerving path of fairness and righteousness.

Deuteronomy 17:12

purge the evil: The effects of evil should not be allowed to fester in the community. Like a cancer, they must be completely eradicated.

Deuteronomy 17:15

the man the Lord your God chooses: Human monarchy was not contrary to God’s will for Israel (cp. [1 Sam 8:6–7](#))—God promised Abraham and Sarah that their descendants would include kings ([Gen 17:6, 16](#); see also [Gen 35:11](#)). But the abuses of kingship were condemned. The theology that views the Messiah in a kingly role ([2 Sam 7:11–15](#); [Pss 2; 110](#); [Isa 9:6–7](#)) provides for both human and divine royalty.

Deuteronomy 17:16

never return to Egypt: Going there would show a king’s lack of dependence on God, who had

redeemed Israel from bondage to Egypt. The best horses were found in Egypt (see [1 Kgs 10:28–29](#)).

Deuteronomy 17:17

many wives: Polygamy is neither prohibited nor sanctioned here. This guideline was meant to moderate and regulate the practice. In the ancient world, kings married many wives to cement political alliances with other kingdoms, showing trust in human power rather than God’s provision. David ([2 Sam 5:13](#); [12:11](#)) and Solomon ([1 Kgs 11:3–4](#)) both ignored this warning to their own great harm and that of the nation. • must not accumulate: The amassing of wealth was another sign of dependence on human resources.

Deuteronomy 17:18

This body of instruction (literally *this torah*) refers to the book of Deuteronomy or perhaps only to this passage concerning the Israelite monarchy. For *torah*, see study note on 4:44.

Deuteronomy 18:1

The term Levitical priests described the entire tribe of Levi. Technically, however, only Aaron’s descendants were priests. The non-priestly Levites were their assistants (see [12:12](#)).

Deuteronomy 18:2

The Lord himself is their special possession: The allotment of the Levites was spiritual, not territorial or material. They possessed the Lord by giving their whole lives to his service. This idea is a remarkable inverse of the idea that Israel was the Lord’s possession (see [7:6](#)).

Deuteronomy 18:3

In the dietary fare of ancient Israel, the shoulder, the cheeks, and the stomach of oxen and sheep were the choice cuts. God’s priestly servants were to be honored by receiving the very best (see [Lev 7:28–34](#)).

Deuteronomy 18:8

support from his family: Although Levites were in full-time ministry at the Tabernacle and (later) the Temple, they could still hold material assets of their own (see [Num 35:1-8](#)). The Levites were to be supported by the regular offerings designated for that purpose without having to forfeit any of their own assets.

Deuteronomy 18:10

never sacrifice your son or daughter as a burnt offering: Some Canaanite religions included child sacrifice to appease their gods. Israel was strictly warned never to engage in this practice ([Exod 34:15-16](#); [Lev 18:21](#); [20:2-5](#)). When they did, it aroused God's judgment ([2 Kgs 17:16-17](#); [21:6](#); [Ezek 23:37](#)). • fortune-telling: Throughout the ancient Near East, diviners were considered experts at reading and interpreting omens. Divination was commonly done through *extispicy*, the examination of livers, kidneys, and other internal organs of various animals. • sorcery: Sorcerers conjured up the spirits of the dead. • Divining cups were often used to interpret omens (see [Gen 44:5](#)). Drops of oil would be placed in containers of water, and the spread of the oil communicated some message to the expert. A parallel would be reading tea leaves. • The practice of witchcraft included performing unusual acts or signs ([Exod 7:11](#)) to mislead people ([Mal 3:5](#)).

Deuteronomy 18:11

cast spells: These incantations were to destroy or injure others by invoking curses on them. The false prophet Balaam was hired for this purpose against Israel ([Num 22:2-6](#)). • Mediums and psychics were especially adept at conjuring up and communicating with the spirits of the dead (see [1 Sam 28:3-25](#)).

Deuteronomy 18:15

A prophet like me would be beyond the ordinary because Moses was without peer among the prophets (see [34:10-11](#)). This prophet would be from among your fellow Israelites (literally *from among your brothers*), and Israel was required to listen to him ([18:19](#)). The prophets of Old

Testament Israel would partially fulfill the function of God's spokesman to whom Israel must listen. Later, Judaism looked for this prophet as a major messianic figure (see [John 1:21](#); [6:14](#); [7:40](#)); the New Testament identifies Jesus as this prophet ([Acts 3:18-26](#)).

Deuteronomy 18:18

The prophet ([18:15](#)) would be the Lord's spokesman, as Moses was (see [4:10-17](#); [Exod 7:1](#)).

Deuteronomy 18:19

Not to listen to the Lord's spokesman is not to listen to the Lord.

Deuteronomy 18:22

Any prophet whose prediction fails must be branded as false, even if he claims to speak for God. The mere claim is insufficient if it goes unfulfilled.

Deuteronomy 19:1-13

Cities of refuge ([19:2](#)) were strategically located throughout the land so those accused of homicide could find protective sanctuary until their cases came to trial (see [4:41](#); [Num 35:6-29](#)).

Deuteronomy 19:2

The three cities were those in Canaan, west of the Jordan; there were three more in Transjordan (see [Num 35:13-14](#); [Josh 20:7](#)).

Deuteronomy 19:4

A slayer who kills . . . unintentionally does not plan ahead of time to commit the act (see [17:8](#)).

Deuteronomy 19:6

avenger (literally *the redeemer of blood*): The law allowed murder to be avenged by members of the victim's family. When they found the killer, they

could put him to death ([Num 35:16-21](#)). The idea was that blood shed by the victim must be paid for by the blood of the person responsible for the act (see [Gen 4:15](#); [9:6](#)). In this way, the land polluted by the shed blood could be purified ([Num 35:33-34](#)).

Deuteronomy 19:9

If Israel proved faithful to the covenant ([19:8](#)), God would grant the nation even more territory, so much so that three additional cities of refuge would be needed. Sadly, this need never arose because of Israel's disobedience to the Lord.

Deuteronomy 19:11

The Hebrew term rendered is hostile (literally *is a hater*) indicates a constant and long-standing hateful attitude, which constituted evidence that the killer was predisposed to commit a crime and therefore probably did it.

Deuteronomy 19:13

Purge (literally *burn*): The only way for the land to be free of culpability in matters of homicide was for blood vengeance to be enacted, which would burn out the impurity. See also [13:5](#); [17:12](#).

Deuteronomy 19:15

The word of one witness alone would count no more than the word of the accused. However, two or three witnesses would confirm or discount each other's testimony. For New Testament references to this law, see [Matt 18:15-20](#); [John 8:17-18](#); [2 Cor 13:1-2](#) and study note.

Deuteronomy 19:21

The legal principle described as life for life is known as *lex talionis* ("law of retaliation"), according to which the punishment must fit the crime (see [Exod 21:23](#); [Lev 24:20](#)); it should be neither too lenient nor too severe. Appropriate punishment is a necessary function of government (cp. [Rom 13:1-7](#)), and it served to maintain Israel's spiritual integrity as God's people (see study note

on Deut 17:7). But vengeance belongs to God, not individuals (see [1 Sam 25:26](#), [33](#); [Matt 5:38-39](#); [1 Cor 6:1-8](#)).

Deuteronomy 20:4

He will fight for you: This promise affirms that God initiates wars, carries them out, and brings them to successful conclusion against his enemies. The purpose of war initiated by God was to eradicate hopelessly unrepentant enemies and prevent them from contaminating his people (see [1:30](#)).

Deuteronomy 20:7

someone else would marry her: In this situation, a man who died would be deprived of offspring to carry on his name, which was a great tragedy in ancient Israel.

Deuteronomy 20:10-15

The people in the land had already been placed under the ban ([7:1-6](#)), so this instruction refers to those whom Israel would engage outside the land ([20:15](#)).

Deuteronomy 20:11

forced labor: Involuntary service was pressed upon prisoners of war and sometimes on Israelites ([1 Kgs 5:13-18](#); [9:15](#), [21](#); [12:18](#)).

Deuteronomy 20:15

Places described as distant towns were outside the boundaries of the Promised Land.

Deuteronomy 20:19

do not cut down the trees: Ordinarily, trees might be cut down during a war so the enemy could not benefit from them. However, since the Israelites were occupying the enemy's former land, the trees could be of use to them.

Deuteronomy 20:20

This equipment consisted of the materials built up against a city wall as part of the effort to bring it under siege.

Deuteronomy 21:1

In contrast to the word translated *murder* in the Ten Commandments (see study note on 5:17), the Hebrew verb here translated murdered (literally *pierced through*) indicates clear evidence that the death was not by natural causes.

Deuteronomy 21:1–9

The guilt of murder was usually removed through the death of the murderer ([19:11–13](#); [Num 35:30–34](#)). However, if the murderer was unknown, the guilt could still be removed by using this ritual.

Deuteronomy 21:3–8

An avenger from the victim's family ([19:6–7](#); [Num 35:16–29](#)) could not hold the whole community responsible.

Deuteronomy 21:4

The stream would be an ever-flowing (perennial) brook located in an isolated area, free of contaminants.

Deuteronomy 21:6

wash their hands: This ancient practice asserted innocence (cp. [Matt 27:24](#)); by it the community would declare that it was not responsible for a crime committed in its vicinity.

Deuteronomy 21:12

To shave her head and cut her nails demonstrated a captive woman's separation from her home and family. She was cutting off the past to join a new family and community.

Deuteronomy 21:13

To change the clothes she was wearing symbolically communicated taking on a new life and identifying with a new family.

Deuteronomy 21:14

humiliated her: By first taking her prisoner and then divorcing her, a captive woman's husband devalued her. To protect her from further disgrace, the law prohibited him from selling her as a slave or from using her as one. Instead, she must be allowed to go free.

Deuteronomy 21:15–17

The law required that a firstborn son receive the greater share of his father's inheritance (see [21:15–16](#); [2 Kgs 2:9](#)). The custom of giving the firstborn son a double portion is first recorded here but was implied in earlier practice (see [Gen 25:31–34](#); [27:1–4](#); [48:8–22](#)). • son of his father's virility: The eldest male child carried this distinction because he proved that the man was capable of siring children, and a boy in particular.

Deuteronomy 21:20

Calling someone a glutton and a drunkard was probably a proverbial cliché suggesting self-indulgence and laziness. Such a son was a good-for-nothing who rebelled against his parents and thus also against the community and divine authority (see [Prov 23:20–21](#)).

Deuteronomy 21:22

hung on a tree: This was not the method of execution, at least in this text. It was a shameful display of those already put to death for capital offenses, probably to show the Lord's hatred of sin and to deter others who might commit such acts (see also [Gen 40:19, 22](#); [Josh 10:26](#); [2 Sam 4:12; 21:12](#); [Esth 2:23](#); [7:10](#)).

Deuteronomy 21:23

for anyone who is hung: The Greek version reads *for everyone who is hung on a tree*. Cp. [Gal 3:13](#), which explains how this proverb applies to Jesus. • cursed in the sight of God: Unrepentant sinners do fall under God's judgment. However, the idea of this proverb is probably that whoever saw a person in this condition would naturally conclude that God had cursed that person, when in fact the person could have been misjudged or even lynched.

Deuteronomy 22:1

don't ignore your responsibility: An individual was not to avoid a troubled scene by pretending not to see what was going on. To do so would be a failure of the individual's responsibility to the covenant community.

Deuteronomy 22:5

Adopting the dress and behavior of the opposite gender unnaturally blurs the lines between things that should be kept separate and distinct (also [22:9-11](#)).

Deuteronomy 22:9

any other crop between the rows: This would bring about a mingling of things that should be kept separate.

Deuteronomy 22:10

Plowing with an ox and a donkey would be inefficient; this example illustrates the principle of separation and order (see also [2 Cor 6:14-18](#)).

Deuteronomy 22:11

Keeping wool and linen separate illustrated Israel's separation as God's holy people (see also [Lev 19:19](#)).

Deuteronomy 22:12

Placing four tassels on the hem of a garment probably reminded the wearer to be loyal to the covenant, similar to tying a string around one's finger (see [Num 15:37-41](#)).

Deuteronomy 22:14

A husband who discovered evidence that his wife had lost her virginity prior to marriage (see [22:15](#)) would accuse her of shameful conduct.

Deuteronomy 22:15

proof of her virginity: A blood-stained cloth would indicate that the woman's hymen was ruptured by her first act of intercourse with her husband.

Deuteronomy 22:17

The bed sheet (literally *covering*) might also have been a garment of some kind, such as a nightgown.

Deuteronomy 22:19

100 pieces of silver: The husband, who had already paid the woman's father the normal bride price, must now pay additional compensation for defaming her character.

Deuteronomy 22:21

by being promiscuous (literally *acting as a prostitute*): A single act of sexual intercourse by an unmarried woman was enough to earn this disgraceful label and the death penalty.

Deuteronomy 22:24

Because betrothal was tantamount to marriage in the Old Testament, another man's wife in this passage technically refers to a fiancée.

Deuteronomy 22:29

fifty pieces of silver: The father could still expect a dowry for his unmarried daughter (see [Gen 34:12](#); [Exod 22:16](#)). • he must marry: The assumption is that the girl and her father were willing to undertake the arrangement (see [Exod 22:17](#)).

Deuteronomy 22:30

The phrase his father's former wife does not refer to a man's own mother because incest was a more serious crime (see [Lev 18:7–8, 29](#)).

Deuteronomy 23:1

Emasculation, associated with certain pagan rituals and customs, was abhorrent to the Lord (cp. [Isa 56:3–4](#)).

Deuteronomy 23:3

No Ammonite or Moabite: These nations were Lot's descendants by his incestuous daughters (see study notes on 2:9, 19). In addition, they had forbidden Israel access to their lands during their desert wanderings ([23:4](#)). • Exclusion for ten generations means an indefinitely long period of time.

Deuteronomy 23:4

Pethor is now identified with Pitru in Mesopotamia (see study note on Num 22:5–6). • Aram-naharaim ("Aram of the two rivers") lies between the Euphrates and the Balih Rivers in upper Mesopotamia.

Deuteronomy 23:7

The Edomites were descendants of Jacob's brother, Esau (see [2:8](#)).

Deuteronomy 23:8

third generation: Following a long period of probation, Edomites and Egyptians who lived in

Israel could worship the Lord as converts to the faith.

Deuteronomy 23:10

nocturnal emission: Although they might have been unintentional or involuntary, these discharges rendered a man ceremonially unclean (see [Lev 15:16–18](#)).

Deuteronomy 23:12

outside the camp: Defecation is a normal bodily function, but it brought ritual impurity and therefore violated God's holiness.

Deuteronomy 23:13

It would be disgusting and shameful to have an open latrine outside the camp, let alone within it.

Deuteronomy 23:14

shameful thing (literally *nakedness of a thing*): Because the camp of God's army was holy, it was necessary that nakedness, especially of the genitalia, not be exposed within the camp (cp. [Gen 2:25](#); [3:7–11](#); [9:21–23](#); [Exod 20:26](#); [Isa 47:3](#); [Rev 3:18](#)).

Deuteronomy 23:17

A temple prostitute was commonly a part of Canaanite religious rituals, but they were forbidden in Israel.

Deuteronomy 23:18

a man: The Hebrew word (literally *a dog*) was a derogatory term for homosexual men, who often took part in Canaanite religious ceremonies.

Deuteronomy 23:19–20

The word translated interest is related to a noun meaning "bite." Charging interest was to "put the

bite” on the debtor. See also [Exod 22:25](#); [Lev 25:36-37](#); [Neh 5:1-13](#); [Ps 15:5](#).

Deuteronomy 23:24

your neighbor’s vineyard: In a certain sense, God owned all the land and provided it to its human occupants. Therefore, no one had the right to make an exclusive claim to it. On the other hand, renters had rights to privacy and to a measure of control over what had been allotted to them. Trespassing was permitted within this context but not with the intention of theft. One could, however, pluck a few grapes or kernels of grain to eat along the way (see [Matt 12:1-8](#); [Mark 2:23-28](#); [Luke 6:1-5](#)).

Deuteronomy 24:1

something wrong: This phrase indicates sexual impurity or some other impropriety. It does not pertain to adultery, which would have required the death penalty ([22:22](#)). • a document of divorce: This procedure was a concession; initiating a divorce in such cases was optional and not necessarily desirable (see [Mal 2:16](#); [Matt 5:31-32](#); [Mark 10:2-12](#)).

Deuteronomy 24:4

Perhaps the woman is described as defiled because she had two husbands; returning to the first husband would be considered adultery. • guilt upon the land: The concept of community was so strong in ancient Israel that the individual’s identity almost merged with that of the community. The sin of one individual had collective, corporate consequences.

Deuteronomy 24:6

the owner uses it to make a living (literally *it is his life*): Without his tool, the owner of the millstone might perish. The law imposed a limit on what could secure a loan. The millstone probably represents any means by which an individual made his living.

Deuteronomy 24:8

serious skin diseases: Medical science has determined that this does not refer to leprosy (i.e., Hansen’s disease) per se.

Deuteronomy 24:11

wait outside: Even debtors were to be allowed their dignity and spared unnecessary embarrassment. A creditor was not to invade the debtor’s privacy when collecting from him.

Deuteronomy 24:13

Return the cloak . . . by sunset: The law was merciful.

Deuteronomy 24:17

True justice must be given (literally *do not deprive of justice*): The people of Israel were to vigorously resist discrimination against the weakest and most vulnerable people in society. Israel had been redeemed from such a status in Egypt, and their experience should help them realize how to treat others in similar circumstances ([24:18](#)).

Deuteronomy 25:3

During a whipping, the maximum number of strikes allowed was forty lashes. Fewer could be given depending on the situation ([25:2](#)). As people created in the image of God, they deserved mercy and respect, even if they did wrong. In later Judaism, they gave thirty-nine lashes (see [2 Corinthians 11:24](#) and note).

Deuteronomy 25:4

You must not muzzle an ox: The animal had to be able to eat the grain as it worked (cp. [1 Cor 9:9-14](#); [1 Tim 5:17-18](#)).

Deuteronomy 25:5

The term rendered duties of a brother-in-law refers to the levirate (Latin for *brother-in-law*)

marriage custom. The brother of a deceased man was encouraged to marry his brother's widow and father her children so that the name of the dead brother would not be forgotten. For examples of this custom, see [Gen 38:6–11](#); [Ruth 3:12–13](#); [4:1–12](#); [Luke 20:27–33](#).

Deuteronomy 25:9

pull his sandal from his foot: Using footwear, which touched the ground, the brother-in-law showed that he relinquished any claim to his dead brother's estate ([Ruth 4:7](#)). • spit in his face: This is an almost universal gesture of utter contempt (see [Num 12:14](#)).

Deuteronomy 25:10

his family will be referred to: If a man refused to perpetuate his brother's name, he would be spoken of in a derogatory way.

Deuteronomy 25:11–12

cut off her hand: The woman's act would emasculate the man, depriving him of (or *cutting off* from him) any offspring. As with the previous law ([25:9](#)), the punishment fits the crime (*lex talionis*; see study note on 19:21).

Deuteronomy 25:13–14

You must use accurate scales . . . full and honest measures (Hebrew *you must not have stone and stone, large and small, . . . ephah and ephah, large and small*): Merchants were not to use two sets of weights and measures for cheating customers—a heavier weight or measure when purchasing goods (thus reducing their own cost) and a lighter one when selling them (thus increasing their own profit).

Deuteronomy 25:17

The Amalekites were tribal peoples who attacked Israel's rear flanks during the Sinai wilderness wandering ([Exod 17:8–16](#)). They were apparently related to the Edomites ([Gen 36:12](#)).

Deuteronomy 25:19

destroy: God authorized war against his enemies. Later, Samuel commanded Saul to completely destroy the Amalekites, something he only partially accomplished ([1 Sam 15](#)). As a result, God rejected Saul as king. • from under heaven: The Amalekites were to be obliterated completely (see study note on Deut 2:34).

Deuteronomy 26:1–15

Under the terms of the covenant, the Great King required that his subjects render him tribute annually or even more frequently. Since Israel was an agrarian society, God required offerings of animal, vegetable, or grain products. This tribute specifically celebrated the mighty Exodus redemption.

Deuteronomy 26:5

Jacob's mother (Rebekah) was an Aramean ([Gen 24:10](#); [25:20, 26](#)), and Jacob also lived in Aram for many years ([Gen 31:41–42](#)). His lifestyle was seminomadic (wandering). • few in number: Jacob and his family totaled only seventy when they went to Egypt (see [Gen 46:27](#); [Exod 1:5](#)).

Deuteronomy 26:11

In Israelite society, foreigners (literally *sojourners*) were resident aliens; see also study note on 10:18.

Deuteronomy 26:12

Every third year the tithe was gathered for the Levites and other dependents; see also study note on 14:28.

Deuteronomy 26:13

I have taken (literally *burned*) the sacred gift: This phrase means that the donor had given his own property to the Levites and to others in need.

Deuteronomy 26:14

offered any of it to the dead: These pagan rituals were intended to sustain the dead through food offerings. Such food would be unacceptable as a part of the tithe given to the Levites.

Deuteronomy 26:16

wholeheartedly (literally *with all your heart and with all your soul*): This Hebrew phrase is a clear reference to the *Shema*, the foundational statement of Israel's faith and covenant commitment (see [6:4-5](#) and study notes). There could be no halfhearted compliance with God's high and holy expectations; it must be all or nothing.

Deuteronomy 26:16-19

Having laid out the great covenant principles (chs [5-11](#)) and clarified their application (chs [12-26](#)), Moses urged the people to obey the covenant with all their hearts. The Lord had called them into a special relationship with himself, a privilege that required obedience to the covenant prescriptions. The result of this submission was holiness, a state that reflected God's character and that would flow naturally from unbroken fellowship with him.

Deuteronomy 27:3

this whole body of instruction (literally *all the words of this torah*): This phrase could refer to the entire book of Deuteronomy, but considering the small surface ([27:2](#)) on which the text was to be inscribed, it probably just refers to the Ten Commandments.

Deuteronomy 27:4

The covenant ceremony was to take place at Mount Ebal, a mountain east of Shechem (see [Josh 8:30-35](#)). The Samaritan Pentateuch reads "Mount Gerizim" here, an obvious attempt to justify the existence of the Samaritan temple on that mountain (see [Deut 11:29](#)).

Deuteronomy 27:5

natural, uncut stones: Archaeological research has uncovered a number of Canaanite altars, all built of hewn blocks. In contrast to this practice, the Israelites were to build their altars only of rough field stones ([Exod 20:22-26](#); see "Altars" Theme Note).

Deuteronomy 27:7

Some offerings atoned for sins and trespasses; others affirmed that all was well between the Lord and the donor. For example, peace offerings (sometimes called *fellowship offerings*) testified to wholeness in the divine-human relationship (see [Lev 3:1-16](#)).

Deuteronomy 27:9

Today: The Israelites were already the Lord's people prior to this moment, but each time Israel affirmed itself to be God's people and renewed the covenant (as here), they became God's people in a fresh, new way. Recommitment to the Lord is like beginning a new relationship with him.

Deuteronomy 27:12-26

Mount Gerizim lies just west of Mount Ebal ([27:4](#)), and Shechem lies in the valley between (see [11:29](#); [Josh 8:30-35](#)). • proclaim a blessing: The tribes or their representatives were carefully placed so that as the Levites ([Deut 27:14](#)) read the covenant from the valley below, the other tribes antiphonally proclaimed their adherence to its terms by shouting Amen, a Hebrew term that means "May it be so."

Deuteronomy 27:13

proclaim a curse: By invoking curses on themselves if they disobeyed the terms of the covenant, these tribes served as witnesses and judges of their own future disobedience.

Deuteronomy 27:14

The Levites as a group were stationed on Mount Gerizim ([27:12](#)). The Ark of the Covenant accompanied them, and they offered sacrifices ([Josh 8:30–35](#)). It was part of the Levites' role to teach and proclaim the Torah ([Deut 33:10](#); see study note on 6:8; see also [Lev 10:11](#)).

Deuteronomy 27:15

carves or casts an idol: Such behavior would strike at the very heart of the covenant ideal by violating the second commandment (see [5:7–10](#)).

Deuteronomy 27:16

dishonors father or mother: In the various spheres of human relationships, duty to parents ranked just below duty to God (see [5:16](#)). To disrespect and disobey parents was just short of disrespecting God.

Deuteronomy 27:17

Moving a boundary marker to one's own advantage is tantamount to theft and clearly violates the eighth commandment (see [5:19](#); [19:14](#)).

Deuteronomy 27:18

blind person: This curse would apply to treatment of physically disabled or disadvantaged people in general. Such a mean and callous act was not fitting of a member of the covenant community, in which all were to be treated alike.

Deuteronomy 27:19

It would be easy to put foreigners, orphans, and widows at a legal disadvantage or to deny them justice altogether (see [10:18](#); [24:17](#)).

Deuteronomy 27:20

violated his father: See [22:30](#).

Deuteronomy 27:22

whether . . . the daughter of his father or his mother: Though this instruction concerns a relationship with a half sister or foster sibling, it precludes a sexual relationship with one's full sibling as well (see [Lev 18:9](#); [20:17](#)).

Deuteronomy 28:1–68

This section presents the conditions for receiving the covenant blessing, the nature of the blessings ([28:1–14](#)), and the curses that will come if these mandates are ignored or disobeyed ([28:15–68](#)).

Deuteronomy 28:5

The breadboards were blessed because the harvest was blessed.

Deuteronomy 28:7

In the Bible, the number seven generally conveys fullness or completion. Here, the number indicates that Israel's enemies would be completely removed from the land (see study note on Deut 2:34).

Deuteronomy 28:10

When the nations saw the blessings of Israel, they would know that it had happened because you are a people claimed by the Lord (literally *the name of the Lord is called over you*). When the nations saw Israel, they would think of the Lord and his faithfulness.

Deuteronomy 28:12

his rich treasury in the heavens: This metaphor describes the clouds that provide life-giving rain to the earth.

Deuteronomy 28:13

the head and not the tail: If Israel obeyed the terms of the covenant, it would lead the nations and not be subject to them.

Deuteronomy 28:17

If they disobeyed the commands of the covenant, Israel could expect God to judge them with the curse of agricultural barrenness (cp. [28:5](#)).

Deuteronomy 28:21

The diseases that afflict (or *cling to*) Israel would be chronic, not releasing their hold until the nation had succumbed.

Deuteronomy 28:22

Some scholars identify these symptoms with tuberculosis.

Deuteronomy 28:23

In this graphic picture of drought and famine, the sky dams up the rain, making the earth hard and unfruitful.

Deuteronomy 28:24

The only thing even resembling rain would be the swirling dust that coats everything to suffocation.

Deuteronomy 28:25

This verse reverses the blessing of [28:7](#); Israel would be forced to scatter from their enemies in seven directions—i.e., completely and totally.

Deuteronomy 28:27

the boils of Egypt: See [Exod 9:8–12](#). • tumors: Cp. [1 Sam 5:6](#), [9](#), [12](#). • scurvy: Perhaps dermatitis. • The itch is also symptomatic of dermatitis.

Deuteronomy 28:36

exile you: This prediction had two major fulfillments in Old Testament times—the Assyrian

exile of Samaria in 722 BC and the Babylonian conquest and exile of Jerusalem in 586 BC.

Deuteronomy 28:43

foreigners (literally *sojourners*): In God's day of judgment, those regarded as the weakest and most vulnerable elements of Israelite society (see [29:11](#)) would dominate.

Deuteronomy 28:44

the head . . . the tail: Rather than Israel's leading the nations, the reverse would be true when God punishes his people (see [28:13](#)).

Deuteronomy 28:46

sign and warning (literally *sign and wonder*): This expression indicates God's miraculous acts that arrest the attention of those who witness them and attest to his power and sovereignty (see [6:22](#)). They are intended to produce intense fear among his own people.

Deuteronomy 28:48

An iron yoke is portrayed in various inscriptions and artistic representations. The use of this hard, unyielding metal emphasizes the cruelty and severity of the bondage Israel would experience if it remained unrepentant.

Deuteronomy 28:49

like a vulture (or *eagle*): This simile indicates how rapidly the enemy would come. • whose language you do not understand: Both Assyrian and Babylonian were dialects of Akkadian, a language that was related to Hebrew but vastly different in grammar, syntax, and vocabulary (see [Isa 36:11–13](#)).

Deuteronomy 28:50

The Assyrians were fierce and heartless toward their defeated enemies. A favorite instrument of

torture was a stake on which they impaled their victims alive (see [Isa 33:19](#); [Nah 2:1–7](#)).

Deuteronomy 28:54

A tenderhearted man was sheltered from the dark and disgusting side of life. He had never experienced the horrors that would befall him.

Deuteronomy 28:56

not . . . touch the ground: This woman was so fastidious that she avoided walking barefoot on the soil.

Deuteronomy 28:57

afterbirth: This horrific scenario depicts a mother so hungry as to eat a human placenta and the new baby she has borne.

Deuteronomy 28:58

The context suggests that all the words of instruction (literally *all the words of this torah*) refers to the entire book of Deuteronomy, in which lists of blessings and curses were a major part (see [27:3](#)). • If you do not fear the . . . name—i.e., do not fear God himself (see study note on 7:21).

Deuteronomy 28:60

The diseases of Egypt were not just general plagues but those associated with physical illness (see [Exod 9:8–12](#)).

Deuteronomy 28:64

foreign gods: This phrase does not suggest the actual existence of other deities. The Old Testament is clear that there is only one God, the Lord. However, the pagans among whom Israel would live did worship other gods; the danger was that Israel would adopt the same practices.

Deuteronomy 28:68

The threat of being sent back to Egypt referred to any future exile of God's people, a reversal of the exodus from freedom to bondage. • no one will buy you: The disobedient and cursed Israelites would be so little esteemed that they would be unable to command any price as slaves. By contrast, the Lord had redeemed Israel from enslavement at great cost (see [9:26](#)).

Deuteronomy 29:1

The land of Moab was the region east of the Jordan where Deuteronomy was composed and delivered to Israel.

Deuteronomy 29:2–30.20

Anticipating his death, Moses composed a farewell address, briefly reviewing Israel's history since the Exodus. He charged the nation to pledge their fidelity to the Lord. This section of Deuteronomy makes it clear that grace is not just a New Testament doctrine: It undergirds every aspect of the Lord's relationship with Israel.

Deuteronomy 29:6

but he provided for you: This clause does not appear in the Hebrew but is implied by its context.

Deuteronomy 29:7

King Sihon of Heshbon, ruler of the Amorites, had controlled an area from the Arnon River to the Ammonite border. See [Num 21:31–35](#). • Heshbon: See [Deut 1:4](#); [2:24](#). • King Og of Bashan had ruled an Amorite kingdom east of the Sea of Galilee (see [3:1](#)).

Deuteronomy 29:8

Reuben and Gad and . . . the half-tribe of Manasseh were granted their request to settle in the area east of the Jordan (see [3:12–13](#)).

Deuteronomy 29:11

foreigners (literally *sojourners*): See study note on 10:18. • The saying chop your wood and carry your water was a cliché for any servile work (see [Josh 9:22-27](#)).

Deuteronomy 29:12

The technical phrase to enter into the covenant meant subscribing to the terms of the agreement.

Deuteronomy 29:15

future generations: The covenant made with Moses' generation was also for generations yet to be born. Abraham's descendants of the future would have the privileges of the covenant, but they would also need to obey it personally to enjoy its blessings (see [4:9](#)).

Deuteronomy 29:17

The detestable practices were abominable manifestations of paganism, especially regarding worship (see [7:25-26](#); [12:31](#); [13:14](#)). • idols: The Hebrew term, meaning *round things*, probably alludes to dung. These objects were so reprehensible that they were compared to excrement.

Deuteronomy 29:18

This metaphor describes idolatry (the root), which, if cultivated, would result in idol worship (the fruit).

Deuteronomy 29:19

An attitude of nonchalance or smugness regarding God's judgment would lead to utter ruin.

Deuteronomy 29:20

erase their names: To forget the name of a people resulted in eventually forgetting their very existence. The most unspeakable tragedy would be for God to treat the people of Israel as though they

had never existed (see [7:24](#); [Exod 32:32-33](#); [2 Kgs 14:27](#)).

Deuteronomy 29:21

Book of Instruction (literally *book of the torah*): Here, this phrase refers to all of Deuteronomy, of which the list of curses (ch [28](#)) is a part (see [27:3](#)).

Deuteronomy 29:23

like . . . Sodom and Gomorrah, Admah and Zeboiim: In the days of Abraham and Lot, these cities were destroyed because of their gross immorality; their destruction was associated with sulfur and salt ([Gen 19:23-28](#)).

Deuteronomy 29:25-28

This explanation anticipates a future when people would look back at Israel's history of rebellion and easily understand why they were in exile.

Deuteronomy 29:27

The phrase this book refers at least to Deuteronomy and perhaps to the first five books of the Old Testament (the Pentateuch).

Deuteronomy 29:29

secrets known to no one: There is an apparent contradiction between God's covenant promises to Israel on the one hand and Israel's being sent into exile on the other. What purpose could there be in such a mysterious turn of events? Only God knows. • the terms of these instructions (literally *the words of this torah*): See [4:44](#); [27:3](#).

Deuteronomy 30:1

These blessings and curses: See [27:1-28:68](#).

Deuteronomy 30:1–10

Repentance was the only solution to the threat of judgment. The possibility of blessing and the prevention of judgment both depended on a proper relationship with the Lord.

Deuteronomy 30:2–3

with all your heart and all your soul: The expectation of these verses was clearly articulated in the *Shema*, Israel's great statement of covenant faith and commitment (cp. [6:4](#)). Obedience to the covenant was a prerequisite necessary for Israel to receive God's forgiveness and return to its land.

Deuteronomy 30:6

change your heart: This work of God, initiated by his grace, would result in Israel's regeneration and identify the nation as the Lord's true people (see [10:16](#); [Jer 4:4](#); [Rom 4:1–12](#)).

Deuteronomy 30:11

This command refers to the whole covenant text, all of Deuteronomy (see [4:2](#); [5:29](#); [7:9](#)).

Deuteronomy 30:11–20

Adherence to the covenant terms that Moses had outlined would give life; disobedience would surely bring death. Life and death refer to physical, mortal life in the land—of individuals and of the community of Israel.

Deuteronomy 30:12

not kept in heaven: The revelation of God is not known only to him but is accessible to human beings (see [Rom 10:6–8](#)).

Deuteronomy 30:13

not kept beyond the sea: God's purposes are not in the custody of faraway nations but are available to his people (see [Rom 10:6–8](#)).

Deuteronomy 30:14

The message of salvation is objectively close (on your lips) and subjectively near (in your heart). It is capable of being taught and learned (see [6:6–7](#)).

Deuteronomy 30:16

love the Lord your God: This paraphrases the *Shema*, Israel's central covenant affirmation (see [6:5](#)). To love God means to obey him in every respect, which results in divine blessing.

Deuteronomy 30:19

life and death . . . blessings and curses: This grammatical structure suggests an equivalence between *life* and *blessing* and between *death* and *curses*. The essence of a blessing is life, and the essence of a curse is death.

Deuteronomy 30:20

the key to your life: In its most meaningful sense, life consists of absolute commitment to the Lord.

Deuteronomy 31:1

Based on the context, these instructions refers to all of Deuteronomy (see [1:1](#)).

Deuteronomy 31:1–8

Moses' impending death meant that his role as covenant administrator would soon be over. Joshua had to be properly and publicly introduced as his successor with the same authority.

Deuteronomy 31:1–29

For covenant documents to have abiding authority and relevance, they must be kept perpetually in a place where both parties could have easy access to them. The book of Deuteronomy had to be preserved for future reference so that Israel would

always be reminded to submit to the Lord's sovereignty.

Deuteronomy 31:3

The Lord . . . will cross over ahead of you: The conquest would be God's war. The conflict would be commanded, initiated, and led by the Divine Warrior, the Lord God of Israel (see [1:30](#)). • From the earliest days of the Sinai wandering ([Exod 17:8](#)) to the present, Joshua had served as Moses' attendant; now he was divinely appointed as Moses' successor (see [Deut 1:38](#); [3:23-29](#); [Num 27:15-23](#)).

Deuteronomy 31:4

Sihon and Og: See study note on 2:24; [Num 21:21-35](#).

Deuteronomy 31:6

He will neither fail you nor abandon you: This encouragement for Israel on the verge of taking possession of the Promised Land also states a general principle of God's care for his people (see also [Heb 13:5](#)).

Deuteronomy 31:9

Ark of the Lord's Covenant: This gold-plated wooden chest contained the two stone tablets bearing the text of the Ten Commandments. It was also the Lord's throne, as he sat there invisibly among his people (see study note on 10:1).

Deuteronomy 31:9-13

So that future generations in Israel could be reminded of their covenant obligations, the covenant text was to be read publicly. Doing so was a practical necessity in an era when personal copies of documents were not generally available.

Deuteronomy 31:10

The Year of Release was the seventh year of the calendar, not the seventh year of a given transaction between individuals. All debts were to be cancelled and Hebrew bond servants released from obligation to their creditors (see [15:1-3](#)). • Festival of Shelters (also known as the Feast of Tabernacles): The people observed this celebration in the seventh month (*Tishri*, September/October) of every year to commemorate God's miraculous preservation of Israel in the wilderness. It also celebrated the fall harvest (see [16:13-15](#)).

Deuteronomy 31:12

Even foreigners living among the Israelites were to submit to the requirements of the covenant law. Despite their disadvantaged status, the Lord would provide for them (see [10:18](#)).

Deuteronomy 31:14

Tabernacle (literally *Tent of Meeting*): At first, the Tent of Meeting was a provisional place of encounter between God and his people (especially Moses). Later, the term became synonymous with the Tabernacle (see [Exod 28:43](#); [33:7-11](#); [40:2](#); [Num 11:16, 24, 26](#); [12:4](#)). See study note on Lev 1:1.

Deuteronomy 31:15

Since God is spirit, he cannot be seen unless he chooses to manifest his glory physically. The pillar of cloud was such a manifestation, sometimes called a *theophany* (see study note on 1:33). When the pillar appeared, those who saw it recognized in it the presence of God (see [Exod 33:9](#); [Num 12:5](#)).

Deuteronomy 31:18

I will hide my face: The invisible God used this figure of speech (see study note on 8:2) to communicate the breaking of fellowship between himself and his people. He turned away to indicate his rejection and repudiation.

Deuteronomy 31:19–22

When sung by the collective community in days to come, this song ([32:1–43](#)) would remind the people of God's faithfulness in the past and of their too-frequent disloyalty. The major blessings for obedience and curses for disobedience were implicit in the song. The people of Israel would sing it as a sign that they had placed themselves under these promises and threats. Through music, they would be reminded of God's blessings for obedience and would invoke God's judgment should they prove unfaithful.

Deuteronomy 31:20

land flowing with milk and honey: See study note on 6:3. • become fat: Fatness did not imply obesity or self-indulgence but blessing and prosperity. • despise me: Israel would disregard the Lord and treat him lightly by falsely assuming that their prosperity had come through their own efforts or through the false gods of the land.

Deuteronomy 31:22

Moses wrote down the words: This statement is good evidence for the traditional view that Moses wrote Deuteronomy (see Deuteronomy Book Introduction, "Authorship").

Deuteronomy 31:23

I will be with you: These words given to Joshua were the same words God spoke to Moses at the burning bush, when he called him to lead Israel out of Egypt ([Exod 3:12](#)). The same God, with the same assurance, was able to guarantee the same results.

Deuteronomy 31:26

beside the Ark: Unlike the stone tablets, the scroll of Deuteronomy was not to be placed in the Ark but near it, in the inner sanctuary of the Tabernacle and, later, of the Temple (see [31:9](#); [Exod 25:16; 26:33](#)). • a witness: Like the song that the Israelites were to sing (see [Deut 31:19](#)), the presence of the scroll of Deuteronomy would be a perpetual reminder of Israel's covenant obligations and privileges (see [31:10, 19](#)).

Deuteronomy 31:30–32:47

In ancient times, the validity of a treaty arrangement between individuals or nations was secured by both parties' vows. Israel's promise was in the song of witness that Moses composed under divine inspiration ([31:19–22](#)). When Israel sang the song (presumably as part of a regular covenant-renewal ceremony; [31:21](#)), they invoked upon themselves the covenant's judgments and reminded themselves of its promises.

Deuteronomy 32:1

Listen, O heavens... Hear, O earth: Moses appealed to the witnesses of the covenant to note Israel's confession and commitment as well as its anticipated disobedience and disloyalty (see [30:19](#)).

Deuteronomy 32:2

like rain . . . like dew: This simile shows the refreshing gentleness of Moses' teaching. It should produce the fruit of obedience in the hearts of God's people.

Deuteronomy 32:4

the Rock: This metaphor represents the Lord as strong, stable, and reliable; he is more than capable of providing righteousness and justice (see [32:15, 18, 30](#); [Hab 1:12](#)).

Deuteronomy 32:7

Ask your father: History instructs those who are willing to learn from it. In the wisdom tradition of the Old Testament, the father was given the task of teaching his children the lessons that had previously been transmitted to him (see, e.g., [Prov 1:8; 2:1; 3:1](#)).

Deuteronomy 32:8

God is sovereign over and concerned with all nations and has allotted their land in accord with

his own purposes (see [Ps 74:17](#); [Acts 17:26](#)). • the Most High (Hebrew 'Elyon): Abraham learned this name for God when he encountered Melchizedek ([Gen 14:19](#)). This ancient name describes God's universal sovereignty. • assigned lands: One evidence of God's sovereignty was his distribution of lands to the nations (see [Gen 10](#)).

Deuteronomy 32:9

his special possession (literally *his inheritance*): God declared Israel to be his son, whom he redeemed from bondage in Egypt (see [Exod 4:22-23](#); [13:15](#); [Deut 7:6](#)).

Deuteronomy 32:14

rams from Bashan, and goats: This high plateau east of the Sea of Galilee was famous for such livestock (see study note on 1:4; see also [Ps 22:12](#); [Ezek 39:18](#); [Amos 4:1](#)).

Deuteronomy 32:15

Israel: Hebrew *Jeshurun*. This name, which appears to be derived from a verb meaning "to be upright," demonstrates the Lord's strong affection for his people (see [33:5](#), [26](#); [Isa 44:2](#)). • the Rock: This metaphor describes God's strength and reliability, especially regarding salvation (see [Deut 32:4](#)).

Deuteronomy 32:16

his jealousy: See study note on 4:24. Just as a husband is properly jealous when another man tries to draw his wife away ([Prov 6:34](#)), God was jealous when Israel worshiped other gods.

Deuteronomy 32:17

demons: In the ancient Near East, the gods were thought to protect individuals and places from harm, but worshiping these pagan deities actually amounted to worshiping evil spirits (cp. [1 Cor 10:20-21](#); [Rev 9:20](#)). • New gods were false deities that Israel had never before encountered.

Deuteronomy 32:18

the Rock: This expression draws attention to God's reliability as Father (see [32:4](#), [9](#)).

Deuteronomy 32:20

The phrase without integrity indicates disloyalty to the covenant. Israel had promised to be true to the Lord but had consistently been unfaithful (see [Exod 19:8](#)).

Deuteronomy 32:21

roused my jealousy: The Lord was not petulant because of attention paid to false gods. Rather, Israel had broken their covenant with him by worshiping other gods, demonstrating their disdain for him and his sovereignty (see [32:16](#)). • people who are not even a people: God's purpose for Israel was not just to redeem them, but through them to redeem all nations of the earth. In Israel's eyes, other peoples were worthless, but through God's attention to other nations, Israel would be drawn back to obedience (see [Hos 1:9](#); [2:23](#); [Rom 9:25](#); [10:19](#)).

Deuteronomy 32:22

The realm of the dead was thought to be in the depths beneath the earth, and the entrance to that world was the grave. God is omnipresent, and his judgment reaches the most inaccessible places (see [Ps 139:7-12](#)).

Deuteronomy 32:27

I feared: God is never terrified or intimidated. This fear is concern that Israel's enemies would attribute their success to their own efforts rather than to God's sovereign judgment of his people (see [Exod 32:11-14](#)).

Deuteronomy 32:29

their fate (literally *their latter end*): Israel's future had not been predetermined; this statement expresses how things would turn out if Israel continued on its rebellious course.

Deuteronomy 32:30

How could one person chase a thousand: When God gives his people over to destruction, they are vulnerable against all odds. • their Rock: Here the metaphor is used ironically. The very one upon whom Israel should stand as the source of their strength will desert them because of their own wickedness and unfaithfulness (see [32:4](#)).

Deuteronomy 32:31

the rock of our enemies: In this sarcastic comparison between the pagan gods and the Lord God of Israel, the false deities come up woefully short.

Deuteronomy 32:32

Sodom . . . Gomorrah: These cities were the epitome of evil (see [Gen 18:16–19:38](#)). Pagan perversity and godlessness found their inspiration and source in these cities, and because they were unrepentant, they were utterly destroyed (see [Deut 29:23](#)).

Deuteronomy 32:34

Metaphorically, my treasury is the place where God, as Divine Warrior, lays up his implements of war and judgment until the time comes for them to be put to use (see [1:30](#)).

Deuteronomy 32:36

will change his mind about: When speaking of God, the Old Testament frequently uses figurative language (see study note on 8:2). Human beings cannot understand God's mind ([Isa 55:8](#)), so God uses human language and gives himself human physical characteristics and feelings. Although the Bible frequently speaks of God's eyes, arms, hands, and feet, he is invisible and has no body; these metaphors describe his activity. Similarly, when the Bible says that God fears ([Deut 32:27](#)) or changes his mind, it expresses how God's actions appear to humans.

Deuteronomy 32:37

the rocks: This sarcastic metaphor concerns the impotence of pagan gods (see [32:31](#)).

Deuteronomy 32:38

ate the fat . . . drank the wine: Most polytheistic religious systems that practice sacrifice include the notion that the gods find nourishment in the sacrifices made to them. Israel fell victim to this superstitious belief for a time before the Lord graciously taught them otherwise and restored them to himself ([32:36](#)).

Deuteronomy 32:40

I raise my hand to heaven: This anthropomorphism (see study notes on 4:34 and 8:2) asserts God's solemn intention to keep his covenant promises to deliver his people from their enemies. When God makes an oath, he is not bound to some course of action in the event that he proves undependable. Rather, the statement emphasizes the reliability of God's promises above and beyond his character alone (see [Num 14:21, 28](#); [Isa 49:18](#); [Ezek 20:5–6](#)).

Deuteronomy 32:42

The phrase arrows drunk with blood combines personification and hyperbole to show the extent of the carnage that will result from God's judgment of the nations.

Deuteronomy 32:47

they are your life: Obeying the Lord's words brings life (see [8:3](#); [30:20](#)). • long life: This promise does not guarantee individual longevity and certainly not immortality; it is about Israel's long tenure in the Land of Promise.

Deuteronomy 32:49

The mountains east of the river are a range of mountains overlooking the Jordan Valley. Mount Nebo, a prominent peak in this range, was the point from which Moses could view Canaan to the west and was also where he died ([32:50](#); see [3:17](#)).

Deuteronomy 32:50

The location of Mount Hor is uncertain, but the traditional location (Jebel Haroun) is within sight of the Nabatean city of Petra (see [Num 20:22-29](#)).

- The phrase joined his ancestors is a euphemism for burial.

Deuteronomy 32:51

you betrayed me: During the wilderness sojourn, Moses dishonored the Lord by striking a water-producing rock. This fit of impatient anger disqualified Moses from entering the Promised Land ([Num 20:1-13](#); see [Deut 1:37](#); [3:26-27](#)).

Deuteronomy 33:1-29

On the eve of his death, Jacob blessed his twelve sons ([Gen 49:1-28](#)). As the founding father of his nation, Moses blessed these same sons, now grown into mighty tribes.

Deuteronomy 33:2

This poetic account does not establish an itinerary that God followed. Instead, it portrays God in his splendor as he came at certain times and places to lead his people against their foes in God's war. • Mount Paran is the highlands of Paran in the northeast region of the Sinai Peninsula (see [1:1](#)).

Deuteronomy 33:3

In covenant contexts, *to love* is frequently synonymous with *to choose*. The Lord does love his people, but here it means that he chooses them as his special possession ([4:20](#)). • his hands: This phrase figuratively conveys the security that Israel (his holy ones) had in the Lord. • his steps: Following the Lord requires adopting his lifestyle and going where he goes. • His teaching refers particularly and pertinently to the Torah in all its fullness.

Deuteronomy 33:4

of Israel: Literally *of Jacob*. The Hebrew probably uses *Jacob* because the tribes descended from Jacob's twelve sons are here listed by name as recipients of God's blessing ([33:6-25](#); cp. [Gen 49:1-28](#)).

Deuteronomy 33:6

Moses said this about the tribe of Reuben: The NLT adds this line for clarity (cp. [33:7](#), [8](#), [12](#), etc.). • Reuben was Jacob's eldest son by Leah (see [Gen 29:32](#)). His sin against his father ([Gen 35:22](#)) might explain his tribe's lack of prominence ([Gen 49:3-4](#)).

Deuteronomy 33:7

Judah was Jacob's fourth son by Leah ([Gen 29:35](#)). The anticipated messianic ruler would come through this tribe. This promise was fulfilled first in David ([Ruth 4:18-22](#); [1 Chr 2:3-15](#)) and then in Jesus Christ ([Matt 1:1-6a](#); see [Gen 49:10](#)).

Deuteronomy 33:8

Levi was Jacob's third son by Leah ([Gen 29:34](#)). The Levites, particularly those descended from Aaron, were entrusted with the priesthood (see [Exod 28:1](#); [32:29](#); [Num 3:9](#)). • Thummim and Urim were precious stones embedded in or suspended from the breastpiece of the ephod, a garment worn by the chief priest. These stones could be consulted to determine God's will. Their names may be translated "perfections" and "lights," respectively (see study note on [Exod 28:30](#)). • Massah means "[place of] testing," referring to an incident when the people ran out of water and tested the Lord (see study note on [Deut 6:16](#); [Exod 17:1-7](#)). • Meribah means "[place of] contention," referring to another occasion when the people of Israel fought with the Lord until he brought them water from a rock ([Num 20:13](#), [24](#)).

Deuteronomy 33:9

guarded your covenant: The verse alludes to the incident of the gold calf at Mount Sinai ([Exod 32:25-29](#)) and to the affair at Baal-peor ([Num 25:6-9](#)). The Levites' love for the Lord and loyalty

to his covenant eclipsed their devotion to their own families, averted God's judgment, and brought them the honor expressed here.

Deuteronomy 33:10

They teach your regulations . . . instructions: In addition to carrying out priestly duties such as sacrifices and otherwise assisting at the Tabernacle and the Temple, the Levites had the task of teaching the Torah ([31:9–13](#)). • present incense: This ministry was limited to Levitical priests ([Num 16:39–40](#)). Later, when King Uzziah entered the Temple to offer incense, he was roundly condemned for his arrogant breach of the priests' privilege and was afflicted by a skin disease for the rest of his life ([2 Chr 26:16–21](#)).

Deuteronomy 33:12

Benjamin was Jacob's youngest son ([Gen 35:18; 49:27](#)). Because Rachel was Jacob's favorite wife, Benjamin was also favored. His tribe was blessed by the Lord's special protection.

Deuteronomy 33:13–17

Joseph was Jacob's eleventh son ([Gen 30:23–24](#)) and his favorite child ([Gen 37:3](#)). Joseph and his two sons, Ephraim and Manasseh, received Jacob's special blessing ([Gen 48; 49:22–26](#)). As a result, the tribes of Joseph prospered and multiplied, becoming two separate tribes.

Deuteronomy 33:16

the one who appeared in the burning bush: See [Exod 3:2–4](#). The same Lord who favored Israel by rescuing them from bondage blessed the tribes of Joseph. • the prince among his brothers: Joseph's dream that he would rule over his siblings was fulfilled when they submitted to him in Egypt ([Gen 37:5–11; 42:6](#)).

Deuteronomy 33:17

Ephraim is listed first because he received the blessing of the firstborn over Manasseh ([Gen 48:8–22](#)). Manasseh, the firstborn, would normally have

received the double portion belonging to the firstborn (cp. [Deut 21:17](#)), but Jacob gave it to Ephraim, Joseph's younger son. Moses' blessing reflects Jacob's blessing by listing the tribe of Ephraim as numbering in multitudes (literally *tens of thousands*) and Manasseh in thousands. After the conquest and establishment of the nation, Ephraim became the dominant tribe of the north; later, after the kingdom was divided following Solomon's death ([1 Kgs 12](#)), the name Ephraim was used interchangeably with Israel in speaking of the northern kingdom.

Deuteronomy 33:18

Zebulun and Issachar (NLT adds *and Issachar* for clarity) were the sixth and fifth sons of Jacob by Leah ([Gen 30:18, 20](#)). • in their travels . . . in their tents: This figure of speech (a *merism*) encompasses life in all its fullness for both tribes, from activity (travels) to inactivity (tents).

Deuteronomy 33:19

to the mountain: Issachar was allotted much of the plains of Jezreel or Esdraelon. Mount Tabor, a prominent landmark of this region, was probably the mountain in view because later tradition knows this as a place of worship ([Hos 5:1](#)). The nature of that worship is unclear, but it was probably proper even though it was not carried out at the Temple (see [1 Kgs 18:30, 32](#)). • The phrase riches of the sea might refer to the maritime industry of the people of Zebulun when their western border extended to the Mediterranean Sea (see [Gen 49:13](#)).

Deuteronomy 33:20

Gad was the elder of two sons of Jacob by Leah's servant Zilpah ([Gen 30:10–11](#)). His name means "good fortune," but the message is that the one who enables the tribe to enlarge its territory is the fortunate one. That territory was east of the Jordan and the Sea of Galilee.

Deuteronomy 33:21

the best land: Gad chose this territory prior to the conquest. It was the famously rich and productive land of Bashan ([Num 32:1–5](#)). The commendation

of Gad for carrying out the Lord's justice and obeying his regulations probably refers to the tribe's faithfulness in assisting the western tribes in their conquest of Canaan ([Josh 22:1-3](#)).

Deuteronomy 33:22

Dan was the elder of two sons of Jacob by Rachel's servant Bilhah ([Gen 30:5-6](#)). The name means "he judged." The tribe of Dan was originally given territory between Judah and the Mediterranean. However, because of fierce hostility in that region, they were unable to settle there ([Josh 19:40-48](#)). The tribe then moved to the far north, destroyed the people who lived there, and settled in their place near Mount Hermon, north of the Sea of Galilee and adjacent to Bashan. The historical record doesn't mention Dan's staging area from which an attack was made against Laish, but the phrase leaping out from Bashan might suggest that Dan would attack from Bashan ([Judg 18:27-28](#); see [Gen 49:16-17](#)).

Deuteronomy 33:23

Naphtali was the younger of two sons of Jacob by Rachel's servant Bilhah ([Gen 30:7-8](#)). The name means something like "my struggle." • the west and the south (or *southward to the sea*): The Hebrew word (yam) can mean either "west" or "sea." This phrase might refer to the region this tribe settled in near the Sea of Galilee (see [Matt 4:12-17](#)), known for its fishing and farming.

Deuteronomy 33:24

Asher was the younger of two sons of Jacob by Leah's servant Zilpah ([Gen 30:12-13](#)). The name means "happy" or "blessed," evident in the abundance of olive oil from the orchards that cover the lower Galilean hills and Mount Carmel, as well as the security from danger that these hills and other natural formations provided ([Deut 33:25](#)).

Deuteronomy 33:26

He rides across the heavens: Moses' blessing of the tribes climaxes with praise to the Lord. Like a mighty warrior, God rides triumphantly through the skies on chariots of cloud (see [1:30](#)).

Deuteronomy 33:27

God's everlasting arms suggest his eternal nature (he has always existed and always will), omnipotence (power), and care. God's power would evict the Canaanites from the Promised Land so that Israel could enter and occupy it.

Deuteronomy 33:29

stomp on their backs: Treading on an enemy's back figuratively meant having complete victory over him. The word *backs* can also be translated "high places," meaning the heights of the land and the traditional places of pagan worship—a way of suggesting total physical and spiritual conquest. The Lord promised to lead the way and guaranteed success in the forthcoming conquest (see [11:24-25](#); [Josh 1:3](#); [14:9](#); cp. [Amos 4:13](#); [Mic 1:3](#); [Hab 3:15](#)).

Deuteronomy 34:1

Mount Nebo is a high elevation in the Abarim hills east of the Jordan River. Virtually the whole land west of the Jordan can be seen from this vantage point ([32:49](#)). • Nebo was part of Pisgah Peak (see study note on 3:17). • Gilead as far as Dan was the northernmost part of the land. The Sea of Galilee and Mount Hermon lie straight north from Nebo. Gilead is just east of the sea, and Dan (Laish; [Judg 18:29](#)) was south and west of Hermon.

Deuteronomy 34:1-12

Moses fell short of entry into the land of promise (see study note on 32:51), but God did permit him to share a moment of glory in the land at Jesus' transfiguration ([Luke 9:28-36](#)).

Deuteronomy 34:2

The land of Naphtali was northwest of Nebo and west of the Sea of Galilee. • The land of Ephraim and Manasseh was a large area to the west-northwest of Nebo, the present West Bank area of Palestine. • The land of Judah lay to the immediate west-

southwest of Nebo, from the Jordan River to the Mediterranean Sea.

Deuteronomy 34:3

The desert region of the Negev (meaning “desert” or “south”) extends south from Judah to the Gulf of Eilat (or Aqaba) and thus to the far southwest of Mount Nebo. • Jericho . . . as far as Zoar: These two sites marked the northern and southern ends of the Jordan Valley from the viewpoint of Mount Nebo. Zoar was a city of the plain that was not destroyed in the days of Abraham and Lot (see [Gen 19:21–22, 30](#)).

Deuteronomy 34:6

Beth-peor was where Israel engaged in pagan ritual (see [3:29](#); [4:3](#); [Num 25](#)) and where Moses presented his farewell address (see [Deut 4:44–46](#)). • The phrase to this day refers to the time of Deuteronomy’s final composition (see Genesis Book Introduction, “Authorship”).

Deuteronomy 34:7

At age 120, Moses was as strong as ever and in full possession of his faculties. He did not fail to enter Canaan because he died; he died because he failed to enter Canaan.

Deuteronomy 34:9

full of the spirit of wisdom: When Joshua was selected as Moses’ successor, he had to be invested with the Spirit of God to fill the office ([Num 27:15–23](#); cp. [Num 11:16–30](#)). Now that Moses had died, God showed that Joshua was Moses’ divinely appointed successor by giving continuing evidence of the Spirit’s power and blessing.

Deuteronomy 34:10

face to face: Moses and the Lord had an intimate relationship, and there was no need for an intercessor between them. Aaron and Miriam once challenged Moses’ leadership and were severely rebuked by the Lord ([Num 12:8](#)), who reminded them that they were ordinary prophets that

received revelation by dreams and visions. Moses was not such a prophet. God said, “I speak to him face to face, clearly, and not in riddles” ([Num 12:8](#)). No other prophet in Old Testament times could rival Moses in his relationship with God (see study note on Deut 18:15).

Deuteronomy 34:12

terrifying acts in the sight of all Israel: The people of Israel as well as the Egyptians were impressed by the power of God. They needed a constant reminder to submit to him in reverential fear (see [4:10](#); [5:29](#); [6:2](#); [Prov 1:7](#)).